

CITY: Pg 3

Over 2K E-buses to join Delhi fleet



NATION: Pg 5

Shah reviews border security at BSF post near Siliguri



FILM: Pg 12

'Happy to keep getting lost'



SPAIN, ARGENTINA CHASE GLORY

A Final made in heaven

DAMAN SINGH

NEW DELHI: The meeting was supposed to happen months ago. Argentina and Spain, the champions of South America and Europe, were due to settle continental bragging rights in the Finalissima before conflict in the Middle East forced the fixture to be abandoned.

Perhaps, football was simply saving it for a grander stage. Instead of a one-off exhibition, they will now meet on Sunday with the World Cup hanging in the balance — a final written in the stars. For, it feels less like a coincidence than the natural conclusion to two very different journeys to the summit of international football.

Argentina arrives as champions who have refused to surrender their crown.

Four years after Lionel Messi completed football's most cherished quest in Qatar, the Albiceleste find themselves one victory away from becoming the first nation since Brazil in 1962 to successfully defend the World Cup.



Children play football near a giant football-shaped vehicle featuring the FIFA World Cup 2026 theme ahead of the final between Spain and Argentina, at Sudha Cars Museum, in Hyderabad, Telangana, on Saturday

The road has been anything but straightforward for them. Every knockout match has demanded resilience. Every victory has been wrestled from uncertainty. Yet whenever Argentina have needed inspiration, Messi has remained the answer, defying age with the ease of a player who long ago

stopped acknowledging conventional limits. At 39, he continues to shape games with the calm authority of a footballer who has seen every script before writing a new one. He became the oldest outfield player to play in a men's World Cup final (39 years, 25 days old) when he

takes the field tomorrow. Spain, by contrast, have looked like a side executing a carefully prepared blueprint. European champions, unbeaten in 37 matches and conceding only once all tournament, Luis de la Fuente's team have combined ruthless efficiency with irresistible ele-



WC FINAL

» For the first time in World Cup history, the reigning champions of Europe and South America will contest the final



» One team seeks to extend an era. The other hopes to begin one

» By Sunday night, one football philosophy will have conquered them all

gance. Years of nurturing the same group through Spain's youth ranks have produced a side whose understanding borders on instinct.

If Argentina thrive amid disorder, Spain flourish through control.

Possession remains their calling card, but this is no longer the predictable tiki-taka of old. They do stifle oppositions with their metronomic passing like in the past but it has become quicker, the transitions sharper and the attacking intent far more direct, with teenage sensation Lamine Yamal giving La Roja a fearless edge.

It is Yamal who provides the final with its most irresistible storyline.

Nearly two decades ago, a young Messi cradled a baby Yamal during a Barcelona charity calendar photoshoot. The image became one of football's favourite curiosities. On Sunday, it transforms into symbolism as the game's enduring icon lines up against the teenager many believe could inherit his throne. **Continued on P4**

Wangchuk's fast forward to Hosp



Activist Sonam Wangchuk waves as he is shifted to a hospital from Jantar Mantar, in New Delhi, on Saturday

Dipke's fast begins; Oppn slams govt

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Citing medical advice and Delhi High Court directions, police whisked away activist Sonam Wangchuk to Safdarjung Hospital on Saturday morning on the 21st day of his hunger strike at the Jantar Mantar here, drawing sharp condemnation from opposition parties which accused the government of curbing dissent.

Ignoring police's call to leave the protest site, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) escalated its agitation over the NEET paper leak issue with its founder Abhijeet Dipke announcing an indefinite hunger strike soon after the "crackdown".

The outfit, which has been pressing for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's removal, demanded Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resignation and vowed to press ahead with its planned march to Parliament on July 20.

Hospital authorities issued a bulletin at 3.30 pm, saying

KEY POINTS

- » Hospital authorities issued a bulletin at 3.30 pm, saying Wangchuk, 59, has refused intravenous fluids, oral rehydration solution and other medications despite signs of dehydration and metabolic abnormalities
- » The CJP later said on X that Wangchuk has "not broken" his hunger strike and he will continue it from hospital
- » Using white sheets as a screen, the police personnel approached Wangchuk as chaos erupted in the background, with some protesters jostling with security personnel to approach the activist, who was lifted and carried to an ambulance

Wangchuk, 59, has refused intravenous fluids, oral rehydration solution and other medications despite signs of dehydration and metabolic abnormalities. **Continued on P4**

Speaker clears Sena merger; Rebel TMC MPs to sit separately

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Monsoon Session, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Saturday approved the merger of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde and allowed separate seating for the 20 rebel TMC lawmakers, who have joined a little-known party, NCPI.

Official sources said that with the merger of the six MPs, the strength of the Shiv Sena has gone up to 13. The TMC rebel groups of 20 MPs will seat separately, away from the parent party, the sources said.

No final decision has been taken on the demand of the rebel TMC MPs to be recognised as part of the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and the matter is still under consideration, they said. The TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT) had demanded the disqualification of the rebel MPs. **See P4**

ILLEGAL CRACKER UNIT Blast, blaze kill 9



Police and forensic team members conduct investigation after at least nine persons were killed and six others injured in a blast and fire at an illegal firecracker factory at Ramol area, in Ahmedabad

MPOST BUREAU

GUJARAT

- » The firecracker unit, set up on an open farm, was operating without a valid licence
- » PM Narendra Modi expressed grief over the incident and announced an ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased and Rs 50,000 for the injured

AHMEDABAD: Nine persons were killed and six others injured in a blast and fire at an illegal firecracker factory in Ramol area of Ahmedabad city in Gujarat on Saturday, officials said.

The explosion and the resultant fire occurred at 3.30 pm at the factory located on Ramol-Gatrad road, police said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over the incident and announced an ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased and Rs 50,000 for the injured. Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel announced a financial assistance of Rs 4 lakh to the families of the deceased and Rs 50,000 to the injured.

The injured persons were transferred to two separate hospitals - Civil Hospital in Asarwa area, and L G Hospital in Maninagar. "One person was brought dead to the Civil Hospital along with five injured persons. **Continued on P4**

Strait into storm

US, Iran trade strikes over Strait of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: The United States and Iran exchanged strikes aimed at infrastructure and military targets on Saturday as their battle over the Strait of Hormuz intensified.

The region has endured days of back-and-forth attacks in a conflict increasingly focused on control of the strait, an essential waterway that used to carry a fifth of the world's crude oil. The collapse of an interim ceasefire leaves no clear end in sight for the war that the US and Israel began more than four months ago.

The US Central Command said early Saturday that its seventh straight night of strikes had hit "surveillance sites, military logistics infrastructure, underground weapons storage, and maritime capabilities."

The most significant damage on Saturday occurred in Kuwait after Iran struck a water desalination plant and an oil facility, according to the Kuwait authorities and the Kuwait Petroleum Corporation. Both declined to provide locations.

The strikes injured several people at the oil facility and caused a fire at the desalination plant, forcing several power generation units offline. It was the second attack against a desalination plant in two days in the tiny desert nation, which depends on desalination for 90 per cent of its drinking water.

Several firefighters and a worker were injured while battling two other blazes sparked by Iranian strikes, according to the Kuwait Fire Force.

Iraq said it shot down attack drones over the city of Irbil. Jordan's state-run Petra news agency said that the kingdom's air defence systems had downed Iranian mis-



“THE MOST SIGNIFICANT DAMAGE ON SATURDAY OCCURRED IN KUWAIT AFTER IRAN STRUCK A WATER DESALINATION PLANT AND AN OIL FACILITY”

siles, while air sirens sounded multiple times in Bahrain, according to the government. Iranian officials say recent US strikes have killed dozens of people and wounded hundreds in Iran. The US military also acknowledged that several more service members were injured.

Iran effectively closed the strait to shipping traffic after the war started February 28. That sent the price of oil soaring and gave Iran significant leverage in negotiations. The price of oil rose Friday above USD 86 a barrel, close to its highest level in a month, as crossings through the strait fell to a three-week low, according to an **Continued on P4**

Nat'l awards: 'Article 370' steals the show

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Political drama "Article 370" emerged as the biggest winner at the 72nd National Film Awards on Saturday, bagging the best feature film honour, while its lead star Yami Gautam was named best actress.

Veteran Malayalam actor Mammootty and Bollywood star Kartik Aaryan shared the best actor award for "Bramayugam" and "Chandu Champion" respectively.

Inspired by the government's decision to abrogate the special status accorded to the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, "Article 370" features Gautam as an intelligence officer involved in a covert operation linked to the developments leading up to the abrogation. It is directed by Aditya Suhas Jambhale.

Announcing the awards for the year 2024, chairperson of the 11-member central jury, Malayalam filmmaker Jayaraj, said the film "centres on the mission to fully integrate Jammu and Kashmir into Indian union. **Continued on P4**



WANGCHUK ISSUE SET TO DOMINATE AGENDA Meet today, Session tomorrow

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk from Jantar Mantar, citing health concerns, is set to resonate during the all-party meeting convened by the government on Sunday ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

This meeting, which will involve the floor leaders of all major parties, will discuss several pressing issues, including the alleged embezzlement of donations for the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

Wangchuk's removal from the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protest site at Jantar

The government has announced five new Bills that will be introduced in the Lok Sabha or the Rajya Sabha during the upcoming Monsoon Session

Mantar in central Delhi by the city police will dominate the customary meet.

The alleged mishandling of donations at the Ram temple will also play a significant role in the proceedings. The Samajwadi Party has announced that it will obstruct House proceedings regarding this matter.

Additionally, the government has announced five new Bills that will be introduced in the Lok Sabha or the Rajya Sabha during the upcoming Monsoon Session. These include: Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026: This Bill amends the 1971 law to impose penalties for intentional disruptions during the singing of "Vande Mataram."

Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill, 2026: This introduces stricter regulations for delayed registrations.

Income Tax (Amendment) Bill, 2026: Replaces an ordinance to formalise **Continued on P4**

SKYROOT'S PRIVATE ROCKET MAKES HISTORY, PLACES PAYLOADS IN ORBIT

Milestone: Hello space... Vikram-1 has arrived

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI/SRIHARIKOTA (ANDHRA PRADESH): In a defining milestone, Skyroot Aerospace on Saturday launched the country's first private orbital rocket and successfully placed multiple technology-demonstration payloads into the desired orbit, making India the third country with private orbital launch capabilities after the US and China.

The four-stage, seven-storey-tall Vikram-1 rocket lifted off majestically at 12.05 pm amid cloudy skies from the first launch pad of ISRO's Satish Dhawan Space Centre here, leaving behind plumes of orange smoke and marking a new era in the coun-



An engineer prepares a satellite payload ahead of Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 (Mission Aagamam) launch at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre, Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh

try's space missions. The Hyderabad-based company described Saturday's mission 'Aagamam'

(arrival) as a "grand success". The rocket, named after Vikram Sarabhai, the father of

MISSION 'AAGAMAN'

- » The rocket, named after Vikram Sarabhai, the father of India's space programme, also carried payloads that had postcards, including from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who called the mission a 'defining moment' in the country's space journey
- » The postcards, loaded into specialised 'payload lockers', were placed into Low Earth orbit (LEO)
- » Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace has joined a small and elite group of global companies that have successfully developed and launched orbital rockets

India's space programme, also carried payloads that had postcards, including from Prime

Minister Narendra Modi, who called the mission a "defining moment" in the country's space journey. The postcards, loaded into specialised "payload lockers", were placed into Low Earth orbit (LEO).

It also carried two symbolic payloads — Cosmic Bloom, an "artistic lab-grown diamond" in the shape of a lotus, and a tiny gold rocket with micro-sculptures of three of India's best-known space scientists -- Vikram Sarabhai, Sir CV Raman and former President APJ Abdul Kalam.

As Skyroot's Vikram-1 rocket soared into space, it became the first privately developed Indian rocket to attempt an orbital mission, marking a defining moment not just for the **Continued on P4**

Enforce social media, digital ethics norms for lawyers: BCI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Bar Council of India (BCI) has directed all state bar councils to immediately implement its recent circular that laid down strict norms on advocates' conduct on social media, digital ethics, court decorum, confidentiality and professional responsibility, warning that violations could invite disciplinary action.

In a communication issued to the chairpersons and secretaries of all state bar councils on July 17, the BCI said the circular should be widely disseminated among advocates, law firms, bar associations and legal institutions to ensure strict compliance.

The norms ask advocates to maintain professional conduct on social media and prohibit posts that are misleading, defamatory or disrespectful to courts. They also bar disclosure of confidential client information and restricted court proceedings.

Lawyers have also been asked to uphold courtroom decorum in digital spaces, avoid unethical use of AI-generated content and ensure that all online communication conforms to the ethical standards of the legal profession.

The BCI said the objective was to preserve the dignity of the legal profession and maintain public confidence in the justice delivery system in an era of rapidly expanding digital communication. **Continued on P4**

AIMS \$2.5 BN FROM FCNR DEPOSITS

PNB June quarter profit surges over three-fold to ₹5,253 crore

The bank had posted a net profit of Rs 1,675 crore in year-ago period

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Punjab National Bank (PNB) on Saturday reported an over three-fold jump in standalone net profit at Rs 5,253 crore for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, primarily helped by a reduction in tax payment.

The state-owned bank had posted a net profit of Rs 1,675 crore in the year-ago period.

As the bank migrated to the new tax regime, the tax liability decreased by Rs 3,358 crore, which directly added to the bottomline, PNB MD and CEO Ashok Chandra said during the media interaction after the announcement of quarterly numbers.

As a result, the bank posted its highest-ever first quarter profit of more than Rs 5,000 crore, he said.

Total income in the quarter under review remained static at Rs 37,231 crore, PNB said in a regulatory filing.

However, the lender's interest income increased margin-



ally to Rs 32,897 crore, from Rs 31,964 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

Net interest income too improved marginally by 2 per cent to Rs 10,798 crore as against Rs 10,578 crore in the same period of the previous financial year.

During the period, the bank's operating profit rose to Rs 7,519 crore, as compared to Rs 7,081 crore in the same quarter a year ago, registering a 6 per cent growth.

Asked about the foreign cur-

rency deposit mobilisation drive started last month, Chandra said the bank has collected \$425 million till July 17. "We aim to mobilise up to \$2.5 billion in FCNR (B) deposits till September 30," he said. PNB currently offers interest rates varying from 4.9-6.5 per cent on FCNR (B) deposits depending on tenure and amount.

In a bid to attract foreign currency deposits by Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs) and Persons of Indian Ori-

HIGHLIGHTS

» The bank's interest income increased marginally to Rs 32,897 crore, from Rs 31,964 crore in Q1 a year ago

» Net interest income too improved marginally by 2% to Rs 10,798 crore as against Rs 10,578 crore in the same period of the previous fiscal

triggered by the taper tantrum.

As regards asset quality, the bank exhibited improvement as gross non-performing assets (NPAs) declined to 2.78 per cent of gross advances at the end of the June quarter, from 3.78 per cent a year ago.

Gross NPAs in absolute terms declined by Rs 7,292 crore to Rs 35,381 crore from Rs 42,673 crore, while Net NPAs eased by Rs 699 crore to Rs 3,433 crore from Rs 4,132 crore as on June 2025.

Similarly, net NPAs, or bad loans, declined to 0.26 per cent, as against 0.38 per cent in the year-ago period.

However, provisions for bad loans rose to Rs 792 crore during the first quarter, as compared to Rs 396 crore in the same period a year ago.

Explaining the reason for the increase in provision, Chandra said the bank has made an additional floating provision of Rs 390 crore during the quarter for Expected Credit Loss (ECL) that would kick in from April 1, 2027.

GAIL inks pact with KABIL to boost critical minerals collaboration

NEW DELHI: GAIL (India) Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) on Friday to collaborate in the field of critical and strategic minerals, supporting India's long-term resource security.

The agreement has been signed by Sanjeev Kumar,

Executive Director (R&D & E&P), GAIL and Sunil Kumar Singh, Chief Executive Officer, Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL), in the presence of R K Singhal, Director (Business Development), GAIL, and other senior officials from both the organisations.

The partnership provides a framework for cooperation

in identifying and evaluating opportunities in critical and strategic minerals, facilitating the exchange of technical expertise, capacity building, and exploring joint initiatives across the mining value chain to help strengthen India's long-term supply of these vital resources and clean energy transition.

NEW DELHI: The rollout of E20 fuel—petrol blended with 20 per cent ethanol—has triggered a nationwide debate over its pricing, benefits and impact on vehicles, with industry experts and political leaders weighing in.

Former Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) Chairman and Managing Director M K Surana has dismissed the perception

that ethanol blending lowers fuel prices.

According to a CNBC-TV18 report, Surana said during a panel discussion that ethanol is costlier than petrol for oil marketing companies. While ethanol is procured at prices ranging from Rs 56.71 to about Rs 71 per litre, the ex-refinery price of petrol is around Rs 53 per litre.

"As far as the oil marketing

ICICI Bank June quarter profit jumps 13.88% to ₹15,440 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: ICICI Bank on Saturday reported a 13.88 per cent jump in June quarter consolidated profit at Rs 15,440 crore, up from Rs 13,558 crore in the year-ago period on the back of faster credit growth.

In an exchange filing, the second-largest private sector lender said its standalone net profit grew 15.95 per cent to Rs 14,804 crore for the April-June quarter on a standalone basis, up 15.95 per cent from Rs 12,768 crore in the year-ago period.

The net interest income (NII) increased 12.7 per cent on-year to Rs 24,384 crore in the quarter under review, on the back of a nearly 20 per cent jump in advances and a slight widening in the net interest margin to 4.36 per cent.

Its Executive Director Sandeep Batra said the bank was able to buck a system-wide trend and report an expansion in NIMs courtesy a income tax refund and also repricing of term deposits.

Going forward, channeling-in inflows from the FCNR(B) will be "dilutive" on the NIMs front, he said, but the bank is confident of keeping it "range-bound" for FY27.

Declining to share a target on the FCNR(B) front, Batra said the bank has activated its



international network and also looking for partners to ramp up and make the FCNR (B) a success.

The bank did not offer a guidance on its comfort on the maximum leverage that it is planning for, saying that it depends on a number of factors, including the call taken by its local partners as well.

In the quarter under review, the other income excluding treasury income increased by 16 per cent on-year to Rs 8,425 crore for the reporting quarter and the bank also reported a treasury gain of Rs 151 crore.

The deposit growth came at 14 per cent for the lender.

From an asset quality perspective, the gross non-performing assets ratio improved to 1.38 per cent from 1.67 per cent a year ago and 1.40 per cent at the end of March this year.

Fresh slippages came at Rs 5,500 crore, which was down from Rs 6,200 crore in the year-

ago period but higher when compared to the preceding quarter.

Bank officials explained that there is seasonality every year, where the first quarter tends to have higher stress primarily because of the Kisan Credit Card (KCC) accounts.

Provisions, excluding money set aside as tax, was Rs 1,260 crore in Q1, down from Rs 1,815 crore in Q1FY26.

The bank does not see any material impact of the transition to the expected credit loss-based system from April 1, 2027 and has adequate covers in place for the same, he said.

The bank disclosed that it continues to carry a Rs 13,100-crore provision on its books.

From a sustenance of the loan growth perspective, the bank said it sees adequate opportunities to lend in the corporate book, where the banking system has been slow to grow due to variety of factors over the last many years, Batra said.

The bank does not have any preferences or a list of sectors it wishes to avoid either, he said, stressing that the high credit growth of nearly 20 per cent — one of the highest reported by any bank so far in Q1 — is a function of the economic activity and also policy initiative, Batra said.

Sport

Argentina: Adored & abhorred

Why Argentina inspire devotion at home and disdain in many corners of football world

NEW YORK: For some fans following this World Cup, the calculation has been simple: support whoever is playing against Argentina. Across the tournament, that has meant wearing the green of Algeria, the blue of Cape Verde, or the red of Switzerland. Even the often maligned England got a boost in global social media pledges of support last week ahead of their semifinal clash. And in Sunday's final, it may mean pulling on a red Spain shirt. Argentina are one of football's most successful and recognizable national teams, but also one of its most polarizing. From Diego Maradona's defiance to Lionel Messi's global celebrity, the Albiceleste have long inspired devotion at home and abroad, alongside irritation, envy and resentment from rivals.

MARADONA LEGEND Argentina's football identity has been shaped by extraordinary individual players of global fame. Maradona provided Argentina with its most defiant sporting myth, leading the country to the 1986 World Cup title. His two goals against England in the quarter-finals — the infamous "Hand of God" and a solo run later voted "Goal of the Century" — remain central to Argentina's



It'll be a showdown of football's present versus the future — Lamine Yamal against Lionel Messi



AP

football narrative.

The memory of the "Hand of God" goal still stings for many English fans, while Argentines often view it as part of a larger story of defiance and revenge after the 1982 Falklands War, in which Britain kept control of the disputed island territory.

After Argentina's 2026 World Cup semifinal win over England, players brandished a banner reading "Las Malvinas Son Argentinas" ("The Falklands are Argentine"), in reference to the long-running dispute over the islands,

1 This is the first WC final between Europe's and South America's reigning champions

in apparent contravention of FIFA rules banning political statements.

THE MESSI EFFECT Lionel Messi gave Argentina a different kind of icon to Maradona: quieter in public, but with greater global reach and longevity. He won nearly every major honour at club level with Barcelona, becoming the face of a dominant side,

though that success made him a target for rival fans.

His rivalry with Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo added another layer, splitting global football into Messi and Ronaldo camps.

NEIGHBOUR TROUBLE Argentina's image in Latin America is complex. The country has long seen itself as culturally distinct, shaped by

strong European influences and a football culture that often treats victory as proof of national exceptionalism. That self-assurance is sometimes admired, but in parts of the region it also feeds a stereotype of Argentine arrogance.

Fans of many nations use tournaments to display national pride with drums, flags and chants, but the fanaticism of Argentina can seem extreme at times. And that nationalism can veer into uglier territory. One Argentine TV commentator earlier this month called Mexicans "detestable". AGENCIES

LA ROJA LOOK TO EMULATE CLASS OF 2010 — 2010 all over again? Spain built for this moment, feels Rodri

NEW YORK: Spain reaching the World Cup final is still something of a novelty, given this is just the second time the country has gotten this far. Rodri sees it as the culmination of years building to this point.

Winning the Nations League in 2023 and the European Championship in 2024 set the foundation for the success the team has achieved over the past several weeks. An even bigger challenge awaits against defending champion Argentina on Sunday, and Spain's captain wants his teammates to be more eager to win than scared to lose.

"We've been gradually growing," Rodri said Friday. "We have to keep doing the same things we're doing because it has been a process for all five years."

Spain has only allowed one goal through its first seven games, including a 2-0 win over France in the semifinals. Since a stunning opening draw against Cape Verde, La Roja has outscored its opponents 13-1.

"Our goal when we got to this World Cup was to win the trophy, and we were convinced that we could achieve this," Rodri said. "We've shown that this national team has been able to defeat great opponents." The path to the final



Spain's Rodri during a press conference on Friday

AP

655

Rodri has already broken the record for successful passes completed in a single World Cup

included Mikel Merino breaking a tie and scoring late in the round of 16 and the quarterfinals. It has also including stifling defense and nine saves from goalkeeper Unai Simón.

But Rodri, the 2024 Ballon d'Or winner as the best player in the world, bristled at the

notion that Spain has just one defined brand and expressed a belief about handling any kind of style. "I don't think you've seen the same Spain across all the matches," the 30-year-old midfielder said. "I think Sunday's match will be quite different, as it will be a more physical one and we must be prepared. And I believe if we are known for something in this national team is that we know how to play different games based on the moment."

Sixteen years removed from Spain winning the World Cup for the first time, Rodri thinks the determination of that group can be an inspiration. "We can even do it better," Rodri said. "I think against France, we do one of the best games we ever done as a team." AGENCIES

JAPAN OPEN

Yufei pull-out hands Sindhu final berth

NEW DELHI: PV Sindhu entered her first final in more than two years after Tokyo Olympics champion Chen Yufei of China retired midway through their women's singles semifinal at the Japan Open here on Saturday.

The 31-year-old Indian was leading 21-19, 15-10 when



world No. 4 Chen was forced to pull out with a hamstring injury.

It will be Sindhu's first final since winning the Syed Modi International in Lucknow in 2024. She had also finished runner-up at the Malaysia Open Super 500 earlier that year.

CARDIFF: All eyes of the cricketing world will be trained on Rohit Sharma when the India white-ball great takes the field for the series-deciding third ODI against England here on Sunday with speculation rife on his future.

Amid the intense speculation, the BCCI has asserted that the match will not be Rohit's last in international cricket but

the former India captain surely has a point to prove having struggled in the first two games.

Vintage Rohit is all about effortlessly executing his front foot pull shots off the pacers and manoeuvring the spinners but the 39-year-old has not been able to find any fluency thus far in the series, fueling conversations about lasting till the 2027 ODI World Cup in



South Africa.

The two-paced pitch in Cardiff made life tougher for Rohit who consumed as many as nine consecutive dot balls before getting out. A true batting surface at the "Home of Cricket" may just allow Rohit to regain his rhythm for a statement knock in the series decider.

As captain of the side, Rohit had led from the front

by playing the high risk role of an enforcer in the powerplay. His fans would want to see that same Rohit turn up on Sunday. The express pace of Jofra Archer would pose the biggest challenge for the veteran opener in the first 10 overs.

Current captain Shubman Gill has looked the part in the batting department and would be eyeing a big hundred. AGENCIES

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2,800 E-buses to join Delhi fleet in 2 years

‘Expected to be integrated by August 2028’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move towards achieving clean air, the Delhi government plans to induct 2800 air-conditioned low-floor electric buses in the next two years, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday. Gupta said the induction of these electric buses will also reinforce the government's goal of expanding the city's public bus fleet to nearly 14,000 buses by 2028-29.

"This will enhance the availability of public transport while promoting clean energy-based mobility and making a significant contribution to improving the capital's air quality," she said.

According to the chief minister, the government is aiming to rollout these modern buses from April next year.

"The entire fleet is expected to be integrated into Delhi's public transport system by August 2028," Gupta said in a statement.

Of the total fleet, 1,400 buses will be 12 metres long and the remaining 1,400 will be 9 metres long. The 9 metre buses will be particularly useful on narrow roads and in rural areas, helping extend public transport beyond the main corridors and improving last-mile connectivity, she said.

According to officials, government had submitted its requirement for 2,800 electric buses to Convergence Energy Services Limited (CESL) last year.



Rekha Gupta visited the Vindhychal Dham in UP's Mirzapur on Saturday PTI

Mayor Wahi flags off 135 electric sanitation vehicles

NEW DELHI: Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Saturday flagged off 135 electric sanitation vehicles for the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), with 46 of them set to join the sanitation fleet in the Rohini zone. The vehicles will be deployed in the Rohini, Narela, Civil Lines and Keshav Puram zones, the MCD said. Wahi flagged off the vehicles at an event in Sector 10, Rohini, and said the induction would strengthen the civic body's sanitation infrastructure while helping save fuel. "The inclusion of electric vehicles in the MCD's sanitation fleet is a significant step towards a clean and green Delhi," Wahi said. He said the vehicles would also help make door-to-door waste collection more effective.

AGENCIES

"Based on operational experience with the Delhi Electric Vehicle Interconnector (DEVI) buses, the requirement was later revised and it was decided to procure an equal number of 12-metre and

9-metre buses. CESL adopted a nationwide competitive bidding process for the induction of all 2,800 buses, which will help ensure bus operations at competitive rates," the statement said.

White sheets, plainclothes cops: Inside Wangchuk's hosp move

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: White sheets, plainclothes police personnel and a plan to deploy network jammers marked Delhi Police's operation to shift activist Sonam Wangchuk to a government hospital on Saturday after his health deteriorated during a 20-day hunger strike, police sources said.

The pre-drawn operation was planned overnight following directions from the Delhi High Court and medical advice recommending Wangchuk's hospitalisation, they said.

According to the sources, senior officers received instructions from Police Headquarters around 1.30 am to ensure that Wangchuk underwent a medical examination and was admitted



Security personnel stand guard as activist Sonam Wangchuk is shifted PTI

to hospital.

Soon afterwards, senior officers of the New Delhi district assembled at Mandir Marg police station to chalk out the operation.

A police source said a security

drill was conducted to assess how Wangchuk could be shifted "without confrontation" in less than a minute.

The officers also discussed deploying network jammers around the protest site to pre-

vent the rapid circulation of videos during the operation, the source said.

Around 5 am, senior officers gathered near Jantar Mantar for a final briefing. Deputy Commissioner of Police of New Delhi briefed the deployment before the operation commenced, said the source.

According to the source, plainclothes police personnel carrying large white sheets moved towards the stage where Wangchuk was on a hunger strike.

On receiving a signal from senior officers, they covered the stage with the sheets before shifting the activist to an ambulance waiting nearby.

The sheets were used to prevent members of the Cockerhoo Janta Party (CJP) and

others from recording and circulating videos of Wangchuk's removal, the source said.

"If visuals of Sonam Wangchuk being shifted to hospital had gone viral immediately, it could have led to a large gathering at Jantar Mantar," the source said.

With Parliament's Monsoon Session beginning next week, Delhi Police was keen to ensure that no crowd built up at the protest site, the source added.

There was brief commotion during the operation, with police claiming that some of the protesters attempted to obstruct the implementation of the High Court's directions.

In a statement, Delhi Police said Wangchuk was shifted for essential medical care on the advice of medical experts.

Restaurants, cafes to operate till 4 for 'football's biggest night': CM Gupta

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Saturday that restaurants, cafes and other eligible establishments across the capital can remain open till 4 am this weekend, allowing fans to fully enjoy the final match of the FIFA World Cup 2026.

The defending champions Argentina will take on Spain in search of their fourth World Cup title and a second consecutive when they clash in New York. "Every football fan has watched Lionel Messi make history. Now, history has one more story to tell. A legend. A teenage prodigy. One trophy. One night that generations will remember. Delhi is ready for that night," Gupta said in a post on X.

The chief minister said

the decision has been enabled under the city's 24x7 business-friendly operating framework under the government's ease of doing business reforms.

"With the city's 24x7 business-friendly operating framework already in place under our government's ease of doing business reforms, restaurants, cafes and other eligible establishments across the capital can welcome fans till 4 am this weekend, making it easier for the city to experience football's biggest night together," she added.

The announcement was made with the hashtag #FIFA-WorldCup2026, aimed at giving football fans in Delhi the flexibility to gather and watch key World Cup final matches during late-night hours. MPOST

APMC cracks down on encroachments at Azadpur Market

NEW DELHI: The Agricultural Produce Marketing Committee (APMC), Azadpur has intensified its anti-encroachment drive across Asia's largest wholesale fruits and vegetables market, removing illegal vendors and structures to ease traffic congestion and warning of strict action against repeat violators. The drive, which is being conducted during both business hours and at night, aims to ensure smooth movement of vehicles and pedestrians by clearing public roads and key market stretches of unauthorised occupation, the APMC said in a statement.

According to the statement, a joint team of officials from the APMC's Enforcement, Engineering and Maintenance (E&M) and Security branches, assisted by personnel from Mahendra Park police station,



carried out a major operation on May 30 at Sheds 7, 9 and 13 of the New Fruit Market and the C-Block Chowk of the New Sabzi Mandi.

Several unauthorised fruit vendors allegedly operating without valid licences fled the spot during the action, while goods belonging to other encroachers were seized.

Following discussions with licensed traders at shed number 13, the market committee

decided to deploy additional security guards round the clock to prevent fresh encroachments, it said.

The statement said illegal roadside vendors, carts and makeshift structures in the C-Block area of the New Sabzi Mandi were also removed with the help of police personnel.

Unauthorised structures were demolished using a JCB machine and the remaining material was confiscated, the statement added.

On June 7, enforcement officials removed an unauthorised 20x20-foot tin shed allegedly constructed on land reserved for a park in the Market of National Importance (MNI), Azadpur, it said.

The committee said another special drive was conducted on June 30 in the New Fruit Market and New Sabzi Mandi. MPOST

Absconding mother-son duo held in 2018 dowry death case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Police conducted coordinated raids in Delhi and Haryana in connection with the dowry death of a woman in north Delhi and arrested her mother-in-law and brother-in-law who had been absconding since 2018, officials said Saturday.

They were wanted in a case registered at Swaroop Nagar police station under sections related to murder, dowry death and cruelty.

According to the Crime Branch, the case pertains to the death of a woman in January 2018. An FIR was initially registered under Sections 498A (cruelty), 304B (dowry death) and 34 (common intention) of the Indian Penal Code.

The woman's family alleged that she did not die by suicide but was strangled to death by her matrimonial family, following which the charge of murder under Section 302 of IPC was added.

Police had earlier arrested the deceased's husband and father-in-law during the investigation. However, mother-in-law Kanchan (52) and brother-in-law and Jatin (31) allegedly absconded after their anticipatory bail pleas

were dismissed and were later declared proclaimed offenders by a court.

Police said the duo kept changing their hideouts over the years to evade arrest despite repeated raids at their known addresses.

Kanchan, originally from Keshav Nagar in Delhi's Ibrahimpur village, had been living in Yamuna Nagar in Haryana, while Jatin had shifted to Madhuban Enclave in Dehradun, Uttarakhand, they said.

"On July 15, a team received specific information about the whereabouts of the accused in Yamuna Nagar district of Haryana. The information was corroborated through technical surveillance and local intelligence," a senior police officer said.

A special team conducted simultaneous operations in Yamuna Nagar and Delhi's Okhla area after learning that Jatin had travelled to the national capital for some work.

Kanchan was apprehended from her hideout in Yamuna Nagar, while Jatin was intercepted in Okhla. Both were arrested after verification of their identities and completion of legal formalities, police said.

REPLACES 'ESSENTIALITY CERTIFICATE' WITH SELF-CERTIFICATION Govt simplifies private school approval process

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Saturday approved replacing the mandatory "Essentiality Certificate" required for opening private schools with a self-certification system, saying the move will simplify the school recognition process and align it with the RTE Act, 2009.

According to the Education Department, the decision, approved by Education Minister Ashish Sood, removes long-standing procedural requirements under the Delhi School Education Act and Rules (DSER), 1973, as part of a compliance reduction and deregulation exercise. Under the new self-certification system, applicants seeking recognition for schools will only have to certify that they meet the norms prescribed under the RTE Act, including infrastructure,

Parents' body in Delhi seeks audit of private schools

NEW DELHI: Seeking greater transparency in private school fee regulation, the newly launched Parents Association for Welfare and Justice (PAWJ) on Saturday demanded an independent financial audit of private unaided schools and the immediate constitution of School Level Fee Regulation Committees (SLFRCs). The association also urged the government to establish democratically elected Parent-Teacher Associations (PTAs) in all schools and strictly implement provisions to protect children from harassment due to fee-related disputes. Furthermore, they urged the government to strictly enforce the provisions of the Delhi School Education Act, 2025. Speaking at the launch of the association at the Press Club of India, PAWJ president Divya Mathey said parents are equal stakeholders in education, and should have a greater role in making the school system transparent, accountable and child-centric.

AGENCIES

safety, teacher qualifications and pupil-teacher ratio, instead of requiring prior government

approval on whether a school is "necessary" in a particular area. As part of the changes, Rule

44 (3) of the Delhi School Education Rules, 1973, has been amended to do away with the requirement for applicants to submit a prior notice of intention to open a school and obtain an assessment of its necessity in a particular zone, it stated.

The government has also removed the provision under Rule 50 (ii), which required authorities to assess the real need for a new school by considering the number of existing schools in the locality before granting recognition, it added.

The government has relaxed the minimum land area requirement for setting up private schools, citing Delhi's high urban density. It said the move is intended to reduce space-related hurdles while ensuring that safety and educational standards are maintained.

AGENCIES

Open dining policy struggles as valid licences remain around 70 despite rise in applications

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) currently has around 70 valid licences for open dining spaces, even as nearly 1,500 restaurants and cafes are estimated to be operating such spaces across the city, officials said.

Officials and restaurant associations attributed the low number of valid licences largely to the high cost of obtaining and renewing permits.

According to MCD data, applications under the open dining policy have increased over the years after

the policy was introduced in 2022. The figure dipped marginally to 202 in 2024-25 before climbing to 329 in 2025-26, the highest since the policy was introduced.

In the current financial year, 150 licences have been issued so far. However, the officials said the higher number of applications has not translated into an increase in valid licences, as many establishments either do not complete the licensing process or fail to renew their permits after expiry due to the high fee.

The MCD charges Rs 200 per square foot for open dining spaces and Rs 500 per square foot for four-star and above establishments, in addition to the regular restaurant licence fee of Rs 25,000.

"The restaurant licence fee is Rs 25,000, irrespective of whether a restaurant has 50 seats or 100 seats. But the open dining fee is calculated separately based on the area. For example, if the open dining area is 200 square feet, the fee comes to Rs 40,000," an MCD official explained.

For the hospitality industry, however, the cost of the licence does not always make commercial sense, particularly as open-air dining can be used only for a limited part of the year due to Delhi's weather and pollution.

"Most of the people who have not taken the open-air licence have not done so because of the very high cost. The return does not justify the cost," Manpreet Singh, treasurer of the National Restaurant Association of India, said.

Singh said a more reasonable fee could encourage establishments to come under the formal licensing system, bringing more businesses within the regulatory framework and increasing revenue for the government.

Despite the rise in applications, officials said compliance remains low, and the civic body is preparing to intensify inspections and seal establishments operating open dining spaces without valid permission.

AGENCIES

Displaced families face uncertainty amid SIR

For families without an address, the voter roll has become the next battle

NEW DELHI: When 77-year-old Lallu Jaik left his home near Delhi's Race Course after it was demolished last month, he thought the hardest part would be starting over.

Instead, two months after moving into a Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) flat in Savda Ghevra, the elderly shopkeeper is now struggling to answer a question that should be simple: who will give him an electoral form and what address should he put on it?

Jaik and his 73-year-old wife, Uma Devi, are among hundreds of families displaced from the Bhai Ram (BR) Camp, DID Camp and Masjid Camp after a demolition drive which took place on June 14.

Highlights

» For Uma Devi, the journey itself is difficult. Suffering from severe swelling in both her feet, she rarely steps out of the house

» Before the exercise began, Delhi Chief Electoral Officer Alok Kumar had acknowledged the challenge posed by recent demolitions

While the families have begun rebuilding their lives in the resettlement colony, the ongoing Special Intensive Revision

(SIR) of Delhi's electoral rolls has left many uncertain about where they are supposed to complete the exercise.

"We were told by neighbours to go back to BR Camp, collect the enumeration form and fill it out. But what address are we supposed to mention? Our house there has been demolished," Jaik told PTI.

Travelling back to the old settlement, nearly 45 kilometres away, would cost around Rs 500 one way. "How can we spend so much money just to collect and submit a form? If the process could be completed here, it would make life much easier," he said.

For Uma Devi, the journey itself is difficult. Suffering from severe swelling in both

her feet, she rarely steps out of the house.

She said she was unable to vote in the Legislative Assembly elections last year after she found out that her name had already been deleted from the electoral roll. "I was never informed that my name had been removed. I only found out when I went to vote," she said.

Jaik's confusion is shared by several families in the rehabilitation colony, many of whom say they have received conflicting advice on whether they should complete the SIR process from their demolished settlements or from their new addresses in Savda Ghevra.

More than 13,000 Booth Level Officers (BLOs) have been conducting door-to-door

visits under the SIR, which began on June 30, to distribute enumeration forms and collect details from electors. The exercise, earlier scheduled to conclude on July 29, will now continue till August 8.

Before the exercise began, Delhi Chief Electoral Officer Alok Kumar had acknowledged the challenge posed by recent demolitions.

He had said that when BLOs visited demolished settlements, they would find vacant land instead of electors, making both the distribution of enumeration forms and verification difficult. Such cases, he had said, would be treated as "special cases" and discussed with the Election Commission of India.

AGENCIES

Government has resolved 90% of waterlogging problems: PWD Min

NEW DELHI: Delhi's relationship with the monsoon has changed significantly, as around 80 to 90 per cent of waterlogging issues have been resolved, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Saturday.

The minister made these remarks during his 'Government on Wheels' campaign while inspecting development works across East Delhi.

"There was a time when people prayed that it should not rain because they feared waterlogging. Today, we ask people to pray for more rainfall because nearly 80 to 90 per cent of Delhi's waterlogging problem has already been addressed," Singh said.

"The remaining critical locations, where perma-

The minister made these remarks during his 'Government on Wheels' campaign while inspecting development works across East Delhi

nent engineering solutions are required, are also being taken up and will be resolved in the coming period," he added.

The minister also announced that Laxmi Nagar

will soon get a modern skywalk to enhance pedestrian safety and improve traffic movement at one of East Delhi's busiest intersections.

"Just as Delhi has a skywalk at ITO, we will build an even better and more beautiful skywalk here and dedicate it to the people of East Delhi," he said.

During the visit, he also inspected the Patparganj Highway stretch and the Jhilmil Underpass, two locations that had long been identified as major waterlogging hotspots during the monsoon.

He said that sustained planning, better inter-departmental coordination and continuous monitoring have brought a visible transformation on the ground.

AGENCIES

PARLIAMENT SESSION STARTING FROM MONDAY

Monsoon Session: BJP’s numbers game meets the politics of consensus

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The onset of the Monsoon Session of Parliament on July 20 comes at a time when the BJP in the Lok Sabha appears to have established itself as the predominant political force in the House, even as the larger picture in Parliament remains contingent on the ruling coalition and its allies.

The Monsoon Session of Parliament will run till August 13 and is expected to hold political importance not only due to the sheer number of Bills which would be brought up for consideration but also due to the type of the Bill itself.

The constitutional amendment proposed relating to the issue of delimitation and the increase in the number of members in the Lok Sabha, which would have some bearing on the issue of women’s reservation, is one of the mat-

Highlights

- » The Monsoon Session of Parliament will run till August 13
- » As per the positions held by the parties, the BJP has 239 seats in the Lok Sabha, followed by the Congress which has 98 seats, the Samajwadi Party which has 37 seats
- » The delimitation issue may, in such a case, be a test of the government’s ability to reach out beyond its own alliance for consensus

ters that is very much under the political spotlight at the moment.

As per the positions held by the parties, the BJP has 239 seats in the Lok Sabha, followed by the Congress which has 98 seats, the Samajwadi Party which has 37 seats, the All India Trinamool Congress having 28 seats - 20 members will sit separately, and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam has 22 seats. The Telugu Desam Party holds 16 seats whereas the Shiv Sena and the Janata

Dal (United) have 13 seats and 12 seats, respectively. Thus, the political clout of the ruling parties is clearly strengthened by their allies. There has already been considerable political debate on the delimitation issue, especially in the southern states, where a change in the seat allocation depending upon the population of the State could affect their representation in the Lok Sabha.

The delimitation issue may, in such a case, be a test of the government’s ability to reach

out beyond its own alliance for consensus.

Although the BJP’s numbers give it ample weightage in the Lower House, a constitutional amendment would need a special majority and thus the role of the regional parties and the non-NDA parties may become crucial.

The government may thus be forced into making compromises with parties that are normally part of the Opposition. It may become possible if the regional parties decide to take an issue-wise stand on the proposed constitutional amendments.

Some of the other legislative measures that may grab media attention during the session are the amendment in the Foreign Contributions (Regulation) Act and legislation related to Shiksha Adhishtan, apart from several others that may be introduced in the Parliament.

The government will have to face queries from the Opposition on various other matters from the education and examination system to the economy and governance.

The BJP’s majority in the Lok Sabha is expected to give the government more control over the legislative process and ensure smooth passing of ordinary Bills with the help of its alliance partners.

But, the numbers clearly suggest that the government will not be in a position to ignore the Opposition politically.

The Opposition comprises a significant number of MPs belonging to the Congress, Samajwadi Party, Trinamool Congress and DMK, besides some other smaller regional parties and independent MPs, whose importance might be crucial on some particular pieces of legislation.

Speaker Birla approves merger of rebel SS(UBT) with Shinde-led Sena

Rebel Trinamool Congress MPs to sit separately

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Monsoon session, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Saturday approved the merger of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde and allowed separate seating for the 20 rebel TMC lawmakers, who have joined a little-known party, NCPI.

Official sources said that with the merger of the six MPs, the strength of the Shiv Sena has gone up to 13.

The TMC rebel groups of 20 MPs will seat separately, away from the parent party, the sources said.

No final decision has been taken on the demand of the rebel TMC MPs to be recognised as part of the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and the matter is still under consideration, they said.

The TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT) had demanded the disqualification of the rebel MPs.

The rebel TMC MPs are

Official sources said that with the merger of the six MPs, the strength of the Shiv Sena has gone up to 13

also likely to attend Sunday’s all-party meeting.

The Lok Sabha Speaker had earlier met a TMC delegation headed by its leader Abhishek Banerjee as well as the party’s breakaway group.

A similar exercise was also carried out with regard to the Shiv Sena (UBT).

Consultations with legal and constitutional experts of Parliament were carried out and they provided their inputs to the Speaker to help him take the final decisions, sources said.

The decisions came two days ahead of the monsoon session of Parliament, which will begin on July 20

Past precedents, decisions taken by the former speakers

of Lok Sabha and chairmen of Rajya Sabha in similar situations were also examined before taking the “informed and legally sound” decisions, the sources said, adding Constitutional and legal aspects were looked into.

Besides the rebel groups of the TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT), the DMK also sought a separate seating arrangement, away from the Congress, after the principal Opposition party broke its decades-old alliance with the Tamil Nadu party and joined hands with the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay’s party TVK.

This demand is also likely to be accepted by the Speaker.

Altogether, 29 MPs got elected to the Lok Sabha on TMC tickets in the 2024 general election.

As many as 20 MPs broke away from the party and joined NCPI, a registered unrecognised political party headquartered in Howrah, West Bengal, and sought separate seating arrangement.

JAL SHAKTI MINISTRY’S CAMPAIGN

Hindustan Zinc recycles 23 billion litres of water in FY26

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With a push from the Centre for water conservation through Jal Shakti Ministry’s ‘Catch the Rain’ campaign and other water security programmes, Hindustan Zinc reported savings of nearly 23 billion litres of fresh water in FY26 through water recycling.

While announcing the initiative, the company said that

nearly 49 per cent of the company’s annual water usage gets recycled while its overall freshwater withdrawals saw a reduction, besides maintaining a 3.32-times water positive footprint.

These efforts by Hindustan Zinc are in consonance with the government’s thrust on conservation and groundwater recharge through Jal Shakti Ministry’s various water security programmes and its focus on building climate

resilience.

The company has been able to achieve this through innovative water recovery methods including ZLD (Zero Liquid Discharge), effluent treatment plants, MRO (Molecular Rearrangement Oxidation), and filtered tailings technology to recover over 80 per cent water from tailings, besides a 60 MLD sewage treatment plant at Udai-
pur that is a public-private part-

nership model.

Moreover, in FY26, the company has come up with the second filtered tailings plant in Rajpura Dariba, Rajasthan, to further ramp up water recycling efforts.

“In line with the government’s focus on water conservation and environment-friendly growth, the company is building water security through innovative water management practices.

From Page 1

A Final

There are echoes elsewhere too.

De la Fuente once taught Lionel Scaloni on the Spanish federation’s coaching course. Teacher and student now meet as equals, separated by only 90 minutes from football immortality.

Even the conditions threaten to influence the outcome.

The MetLife Stadium pitch has divided opinion throughout the tournament, with several teams questioning its suitability for intricate passing football. Should the surface slow Spain’s rhythm, it could tilt the contest toward the frantic, physical battle Argentina relish.

Heat, humidity and lingering wildfire smoke are expected to add another layer of discomfort.

For the first time in World Cup history, the reigning champions of Europe and South America will contest the final.

One team seeks to extend an era. The other hopes to begin one.

By Sunday night, one football philosophy will have conquered them all.

Wangchuk

He is being continuously monitored and counselled to accept treatment in the interest of his health, they said.

The CJP later said on X that Wangchuk has “not broken” his hunger strike and he will continue it from hospital. Dipke claimed that they might also be removed forcibly and asked the people to gather at the protest site.

Dramatic scenes unfolded at around 7 am as a large contingent of police personnel, many in plainclothes, descended at the protest site barely couple of kilometres from Parliament House, with paramilitary personnel forming a cordon around the stage where a visibly frail Wangchuk was resting.

Using white sheets as a screen, the police personnel approached Wangchuk as chaos erupted in the background, with some protesters jostling with security personnel to approach the activist, who was lifted and carried to an ambulance. “It happened so fast that nobody could understand what was going on,” said 22-year-old Talha, who had arrived from Patna the previous night after following the protest for days.

According to eyewitnesses, the number of protesters was relatively

less in the morning when police arrived and Dipke was not present as he had gone to freshen up.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Sachin Sharma said that Wangchuk was hospitalised in accordance with the Delhi High Court’s directions after his health worsened and was receiving the required medical intervention.

In a statement, Delhi Police said that Wangchuk was shifted for “essential medical care” following expert medical advice and in compliance with the high court’s orders. Some protesters tried to obstruct the exercise, leading to a brief commotion, but police personnel exercised maximum restraint and completed the operation successfully, it said.

The Delhi High Court had on Thursday directed authorities to monitor daily the health of Wangchuk and extend medical aid if his condition deteriorates

In its statement, police also appealed to the protesters to peacefully vacate the protest site at the earliest.

At the Jantar Mantar site, security was stepped up and gradually protesters started to regroup. Dipke broke down on the stage and his associates consoled him. While he was addressing a gathering hours later, a woman hurled an ink-like liquid on Dipke and was detained. She was identified by police as men’s rights activist Barkha Trehan.

Dipke called for protests across the country against the police action.

In a post on X, CJP shared a video of Wangchuk being removed from the protest site in a white sheet. A frail old man, after 20 days of a hunger strike, was picked up, wrapped in white sheets and taken away by Delhi Police. This is a national shame,” the CJP said.

AISA members Neha, Aameen and Manish, however, continued their hunger strike at the protest site on day 21. According to AISA, protesters formed a human chain around them and stopped the police from forcefully removing the three hunger strikers.

Wangchuk and the three activists from AISA have been on an indefinite hunger strike since June 28 in support of the CJP-led protest over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination and the reported deaths of students linked to the controversy.

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said the action against a person on a non-violent hunger strike was wrong and accused the government of relying on “Asatya and Hinsa” (falsehood and violence).

Opposition parties united in condemning the action and accused the government of under-

mining democratic freedoms, curbing dissent and choosing force over dialogue.

Gandhi said paper leaks, the rising cost of education and student suicides were “critical issues for India’s future”, adding that “no amount of force can deter India’s students, and those of us who love and believe in them, from raising these issues”.

NCP(SP) leader Sharad Pawar, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav, DMK MP Kanimozhi, TMC chief Mamata Banerjee also hit out at the government and said it should engage in dialogue with protesters. “What a shame! The world watches democracy in India being broken by force, shamelessly,” Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray said in a post on X.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Nat’l awards

Emphasising a unified and indivisible nation, it highlights the battle against local corruption and dismantling of a conflict economy”.

Released in February 2024, months ahead of the Lok Sabha elections, the film drew political attention over its portrayal of the constitutional change.

On Gautam’s role, Jayaraj said the actor delivered “a nuanced performance that portrays a law enforcement agent’s unwavering pursuit of truth and justice with sensitivity, courage and compassion. A performance that leaves a profound and lasting impact”.

Actor-filmmaker Randep Hooda won the best debut director award for “Swatantrya Veer Savarkar”, his first directorial venture in which he also plays Vinayak Damodar Savarkar.

The Hindi biographical drama traces Savarkar’s life, including his years as a revolutionary in London, his incarceration in the Cellular Jail in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and his later political career.

Praising Hooda’s directorial effort, Jayaraj said, “Showcasing freedom fighter Savarkar’s early life, influences and contributions to the Indian freedom movement, the director shows extraordinary commitment and command over the craft.”

Mammooty was recognised for his performance in the Rahul Sadasivan directed Malayalam black-and-white horror film.

“Chandu Champion”, Kabir Khan’s biographical sports drama, is based on the life of Murlikant Petkar, India’s first Paralympic gold medalist.

Meanwhile, Telugu science-fiction epic “Kalki 2898 AD” won the award for best popular film “providing wholesome entertainment”.

Directed by Nag Ashwin and starring Prabhas, Amitabh Bachchan, Deepika Padukone and Kamal Haasan, the film blends elements from Indian mythology with a futuristic dystopian setting and was among the biggest commercial successes of the year.

Tamil film “Captain Miller”, directed by Arun Matheswaran and starring Dhanush, won the award for best feature film promoting “National, Social and Environmental Values”.

Set during the British Raj, the film follows a former soldier who rebels against colonial rule.

Rajkumar Periasamy was named best director for “Amaran”, the Tamil biographical action drama based on the life of Ashok Chakra awardee (posthumous) Major Mukund Varadarajan.

Actor Sanjay Mishra won the best actor in a supporting role award for the Hindi crime drama “Bhakshak”, which centres on a journalist investigating abuse at a shelter home.

Lyricist Manoj Muntashir won the best lyrics award for the song “Jaane Do” from the Hindi film “Maidaan”, starring Ajay Devgn. The film is based on the life of legendary football coach Syed Abdul Rahim, who guided the Indian football team during one of its most successful periods.

Strait

international shipping tracker. Before the war began, the US had been in talks with Iran over its nuclear program. Trump now faces political pressure to bring the war to a close and avoid the kind of prolonged Middle East conflict he had campaigned against.

Infrastructure hit in Iran US airstrikes hit an electricity and desalination plant in Iran’s southern Hormozgan province, Iranian state television reported. The attacks hit Bonji, a village on Iran’s coast on the Strait of Hormuz.

Overnight strikes damaged two tunnels and a bridge, disrupting one of the main highways towards Bandar Abbas, a city which sits near the narrowest part of the Strait of Hormuz, according to Iran’s state-run news agency. Iran also reported strikes on the strategic Qeshm Island inside the Strait.

Iran acknowledged “attacks on power infrastructure” during the US airstrike campaign for the first time Friday when its Energy Ministry issued a call for people to use less power in southern provinces “experiencing extreme heat.” The ministry did not specify what was hit.

Iranian authorities said at least 50 people have been killed and

more than 500 wounded in US strikes in the past three weeks, including eight killed in a strike on a bridge Friday.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps on Saturday stepped up its warning that countries hosting U.S. forces should be “prepared to receive a corresponding response,” according to Iran’s State TV.

US officials acknowledged 13 additional US service members — 10 Army soldiers and three Navy sailors — had been injured since Monday, but offered no further details. Since the war began, 14 US service members have been killed and 427 wounded.

Iran has said the strait must be under its sole control and that vessels should pay fees to Tehran — even though the world for decades has considered it an international waterway.

Trump has returned in recent days to his threats to target Iranian power stations and bridges to try to compel Iran to loosen its hold on the strait, through which about a fifth of all oil and natural gas traded once passed in peacetime. The US also reimposed a naval blockade on Iranian ports to halt its shipments of crude oil. Crossings through the strait fell to a three-week low of just eight vessels on Thursday, according to MarineTraffic.com.

Meet today

tax exemptions for foreign investors in government securities.

Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026: Proposes raising the strength of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 judges, including the CJI.

Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026: Aims to restructure and strengthen the MSME sector. [1, 2, 6, 7, 8]

Important pending and deferred legislation:

Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026: Listed for passage after being stalled in the previous session. Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishtan Bill, 2025: Aims to unify higher education regulators, currently pending committee review.

130th Constitutional Amendment Bill: This proposal regarding the suspension of jailed officials was omitted from the agenda.

BCI

According to the communication, the circular provides a comprehensive framework governing lawyers’ professional conduct in digital spaces and reiterates that

advocates remain bound by ethical obligations while using social media and other online platforms.

The BCI directed every state bar council to circulate the guidelines to all advocates enrolled with it, all district and high court bar associations, law firms and legal institutions. It also asked the councils to upload the circular on their official websites and social media platforms and display it on notice boards.

The communication further directed state bar councils to organise awareness programmes, webinars and workshops to educate advocates about the new norms and encourage voluntary compliance with the prescribed standards.

The BCI also asked the councils to designate a nodal officer or committee to monitor compliance and submit periodic reports on implementation and any disciplinary proceedings initiated for violations.

The councils have also been asked to ensure that all advocates sign declarations acknowledging receipt of and commitment to comply with the guidelines at the time of enrolment or renewal, wherever applicable.

The BCI said the circular was issued under its statutory powers under the Advocates Act, 1961, the Bar Council of India Rules and other applicable laws.

Vikram-1

company but also for India’s rapidly emerging private space sector.

Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace has joined a small and elite group of global companies that have successfully developed and launched orbital rockets. The mission marks the arrival of India’s private sector in the global launch business.

Vikram-1 is a seven-storey-tall, multi-stage orbital launch vehicle built with an all-carbon composite structure and powered by in-house developed propulsion systems, including 3D-printed engines and high-thrust solid-fuel boosters.

Designed to carry small satellites weighing up to 350 kg to Low Earth Orbit (LEO), its first test flight is targeting a 450 km orbit at a 60-degree inclination.

According to the company, the engineering data collected during this test flight will be analysed to validate guidance and navigation systems and to guide future refinements for commercial satellite missions.

This historic milestone is also expected to strengthen India’s position in the fast-growing global small satellite launch market,

expanding the country’s presence in space alongside ISRO.

A “planned hold” due to apparent navigation issues forced a revised launch time of 12.05 pm, as against the originally planned 11.30 am.

After its ascent, the primary payloads -- technology demonstrators from Grahac Space, CosmoServe, DCubed, and Skyroot’s SCOPE -- were sequentially deployed into a 450 km LEO.

The launch vehicle also successfully deployed a micro-art payload, an 18-karat gold rocket and a handwritten postcard from Modi bearing the message “Vande Mataram”, along with postcards from engineers, scientists, and Indian astronauts.

“Skyroot proudly named its rockets and engines after these icons,” the company said.

Prime Minister Modi hailed the successful launch, saying it proved the country’s self-reliance push.

Blast

The injured are undergoing treatment,” the hospital’s medical superintendent Dr Rakesh Joshi said. LG Hospital Superintendent Leena Dabhi said, “Nine persons were brought to the hospital, of whom eight died. The condition of an injured woman is stable.”

The firecracker unit, set up on an open farm, was operating without a valid licence, Joint Commissioner of Police Jaipal Singh Rathore said.

Personnel from the Rapid Action Force (RAF) and Ahmedabad Fire and Emergency Services rushed to the spot and launched rescue and relief operations, he said.

The official said a case of culpable homicide not amounting to murder and other offences will be registered under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and provisions of the Explosives Act.

City Crime Branch is carrying out further investigation.

In a post by the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO), PM Modi said, “Extremely saddened to hear about the loss of lives due to a mishap at a fireworks factory in Ahmedabad, Gujarat. My thoughts are with the bereaved families in this hour of grief.”

“Praying for the speedy recovery of the injured. The local administration is providing all possible assistance to those affected. An ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh from PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each deceased. The injured would be given Rs 50,000,” the post said.

CM Patel also declared assistance for the families and the injured.

Zero tolerance against terrorism not statement but Line of Action: Rajnath

Shah reviews border security at BSF post near Siliguri

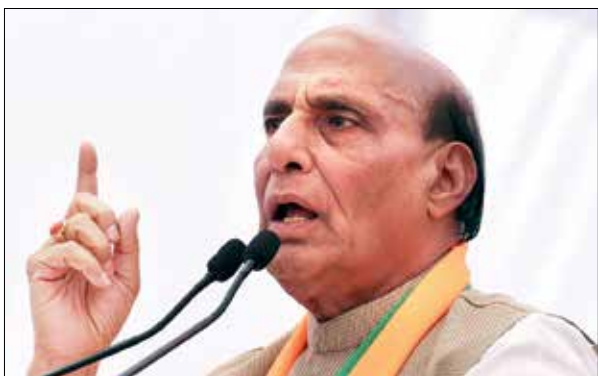
Inaugurates development projects worth Rs 77 crore

‘Need to build education system from scratch to ensure safety of students’

‘Mann govt to continue to fight for employees’ rights’

Youth must choose sports & education, not drugs to build Viksit Bharat: Hry CM

The Chief Minister was addressing the "Ek Police, Ek Sankalp - 'Drug-Free Haryana'" programme organised at the Haryana Police Academy, Madhuban, Karnal, on Saturday as the chief guest. The dialogue programme, held with all Station House Officers (SHOs) of Haryana Police, aimed to further strengthen the resolve to make the state completely drug-free and to formulate an effective



Defence minister Rajnath Singh

» 'We will strike against terrorism not just at the doorstep but by entering the house. The whole world saw this during Operation Sindoor' said Rainath Singh

Shah had reached the Seema Chowki or the base of the BSF's 18th Battalion in Jumagachh



Union Home minister Amit Shah during an inspection of the surveillance system of the Border Out Post at Jumagach BOP of the 18th Battalion of the BSF's North Bengal Frontier, in Siliguri, Saturday PTI



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addresses the gathering during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme, in Dehradun PTI

Addressing the rally in Dehradun Friday evening, he alleged that the entire education system, from top to bottom, is involved in paper leaks due to which 7.5 crore students have suffered so far.

Reaffirming that the Mann govt stands firmly with over 2,100 MGNREGA employees in Punjab, the minister questioned the Centre's decision to shift the financial burden of the new scheme onto states while leaving employees' future uncertain.



The Chief Minister congratulated the 70 students of the Super-100 programme who have successfully cleared the NEET examination and secured admission to medical colleges.

**This Monsoon,
Let's come together for**

Catch the Rain
campaign
take pledge for water
conservation

As we cannot live without water.

Tasks, we have to perform

- Adopt Rain Water Harvesting system in every home, society and workplace.
- Install Recharge Pit and Shaft at appropriate places and repair the unused borewells for enabling ground water recharge.
- Restore Baolis, Wells and traditional Water Bodies and make them usable.
- Enhance water retention capacity by removing silt from ponds and water reservoirs in your vicinity for maximum Monsoon water conservation.
- Please ensure maximum tree plantation to enhance green coverage in water retention areas.

" Catch the Rain-Through this mission, we have to collectively save every drop of rainwater. My special appeal to save every single drop of rainwater collectively."

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi



Government of India

CBC 45101/13/0012/2627

Nine killed, more than 60 injured in Ukraine’s drone strikes across Russia

Kyiv’s forces are continuing their relentless aerial campaign against energy infrastructure and military targets inside Russia

KYIV: Ukrainian drones struck two sprawling warehouses, one of them just east of Moscow, as part of attacks overnight and on Saturday afternoon that killed nine people and wounded more than 60, Russian officials said.

Kyiv’s forces have pressed their relentless aerial campaign against energy infrastructure and military targets inside Russia, aiming to undermine Moscow’s war effort and make Russians feel the consequences of the Kremlin’s all-out invasion of Ukraine that is well into its fifth year.

Two sprawling warehouses of Russia’s major online retailer, Wildberries, were hit by Ukrainian drones overnight, according to Russian officials — one in the town of Kotovsk in the Tambov region, some 360 kilometres from the border with Ukraine, and another in the city of Elektrostal, about 50 kilometres east of Moscow.

A Ukrainian drone also hit an oil depot in the city of Noginsk, just north of Elektrostal, sparking a fire and prompting evacuations of a nearby maternity hospital and a residential building, according to the governor of the Moscow region, Andrei Vorobyov. Drone debris also hit a kindergarten building, Vorobyov said, sparking a fire that has since



This photo, released by Moscow Region Governor Andrei Vorobyev’s official telegram channel, shows a building damaged during a Ukrainian drone attack in Elektrostal, Moscow region of Russia, on Saturday

Two sprawling warehouses of Russia’s major online retailer, Wildberries, were hit by Ukrainian drones overnight,

been put out.

Seven night shift workers were killed at the warehouse in Kotovsk and 25 others were wounded, Tambov regional Gov Yevgeny Pervyshov said. A total of 37 people were wounded in the Moscow region, Vorobyov said, adding that one of those later died in the hospital.

One more person was killed and another wounded in a Ukrainian drone attack on Russia’s Belgorod region on Sat-

urday afternoon, according to local authorities.

Both warehouses caught fire, Wildberries founder Tatyana Kim said, and the blaze in Kotovsk was put out. Images and footage released by Russian online outlets showed a fire raging at the Elektrostal facility, with massive plumes of smoke towering over it.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in a Telegram post on Saturday that

HIGHLIGHTS

» A Ukrainian drone hit an oil depot in the city of Noginsk, just north of Elektrostal, sparking a fire and prompting evacuations

» Seven night shift workers were killed at the warehouse in Kotovsk, and 25 others were wounded, Tambov regional governor Yevgeny Pervyshov said

» A total of 37 people were wounded in the Moscow region, Vorobyov said, adding that one of those later died in the hospital

Ukrainian long-range strikes hit two “significant logistical facilities in the Moscow and Tambov regions.”

“These facilities were used by the aggressor to supply sanctioned components for the production of drones and navigation equipment,” he wrote. An oil facility was also hit, he said.

In the city of Vladimir, some 180 kilometres east of Moscow, a Ukrainian drone

hit a residential building, sparking a brief fire, Vladimir Gov Alexander Avdeyev said. There were no casualties, he added.

Ukrainian special operations also conducted strikes against targets in the Sea of Azov and in occupied territory, Zelenskyy said.

Ukraine’s General Staff said in a statement on Saturday that the fuel depot in Noginsk that was targeted overnight supplied the Russian armed forces. It also reported hitting two tankers, two floating cranes and a tugboat in the Black and Azov seas, saying the vessels were used to transport oil, fuel and military cargo.

Separately, the military said it struck a Project 10410 Svetlyak-class patrol ship in Kerch, describing it as the second vessel of that class hit in two days, as well as a railway bridge over the Bila River near Sabivka in the occupied Luhansk region that it said Russia uses for military logistics.

Overall, the Russian Defence Ministry said its air defences overnight intercepted 379 Ukrainian drones over 19 Russian regions, as well as the illegally annexed Crimea, the Sea of Azov and the Black Sea.

AGENCIES

Israeli strikes kill 3 children & 6 adults in Gaza, says local hospital

A strike on an apartment in the Nasr neighbourhood killed at least five people, including the children

DEIR AL-BALAH: Israeli strikes in Gaza City on Saturday killed at least nine Palestinians, including three children, hospital officials said.

A strike on an apartment in the Nasr neighbourhood killed at least five people, including the children between the ages of 8 and 18, said Mohammed Abu Selmiya, director of Shifa Hospital where the bodies were taken. Six other people were wounded, including four children between the ages of 8 and 16, he said.

Israel’s military said it targeted Hamas infrastructure and had located Hamas militants in the area, without elaborating. Another Israeli strike hit a group of people in the Zeitoun neighbourhood, killing four and wounding another critically, health officials said.

The Israeli military said it targeted a “Hamas terrorist” and it was looking into the results of the strike. Palestinians have reported an increase in the scale of Israeli strikes across the enclave over the past few days.

Despite a ceasefire agreement reached in October between Israel and the Hamas militant group, Israel still carries out near-daily attacks across the territory. It says it is targeting Hamas and other militants who pose a threat. Hamas and Israel have traded accusations of violating the ceasefire.

AGENCIES



KEY POINTS

- » Six others were wounded, including four children between ages of 8-16, director of Shifa Hospital said
- » Another Israeli strike hit a group of people in the Zeitoun neighbourhood, killing four & wounding another critically
- » Militants have carried out shooting attacks on troops, and Israel says its strikes are in response to that and other violations. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed

At least 1,127 Palestinians, including at least 260 children, have been killed since the ceasefire, according to Gaza’s Health Ministry. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed in that time.

The October 7, 2023, attack by Hamas-led militants that sparked the war killed some 1,200 people in Israel and saw 251 others taken hostage. Israel’s retaliatory offensive has killed

73,250 Palestinians, according to Gaza’s Health Ministry. The ministry is part of the Hamas-led government and is staffed by medical professionals who maintain detailed records viewed as generally reliable by United Nations agencies and independent experts. It does not distinguish between civilians and militants but says women and children make up around half of all deaths.

AGENCIES

Iran executes man convicted of killing security force member

DUBAI: Iranian authorities said Sunday they have executed a man convicted of killing a member of security forces during the 2022 nationwide protests that erupted after the death of a woman in custody of the country’s morality police.

Authorities said the fatal shooting took place during unrest in Tehran, where protesters blocked roads and clashed with security forces. They said Aref Khoshkar was armed with a pellet gun and fired at security personnel, wounding Salman Amirahmadi, who later died in a hospital.

According to the authorities, Khoshkar confessed that he fired the gun from the roof of a house and threw it in a trash bin.

The execution is the latest reported in connection with the 2022 protests, which had spread after Mahsa Amini, a 22-year-old Kurdish woman, died in police custody following her arrest for allegedly violating the country’s strict dress code.



AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

Four recent developments—China’s proposal to extend its existing China-Myanmar Economic Corridor (CMEC) to Bangladesh, India’s announcement to resume border trade between India and Myanmar at Pangsau Pass on July 20, the diplomatic agreement between India and China to reopen three designated Himalayan trade routes (Lipulekh, Shipki La, and Nathu La), which resumed in June 2026, and India’s decision to resume tourist visas for Bangladeshi nationals, nearly two years after services were suspended in August 2024—have renewed hopes for negotiations on the stalled Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar Economic Corridor (BCIM-EC), which was initiated in August 1999 but stalled due to India’s resistance to Xi Jinping’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). In 2017, India formally boycotted the BRI, causing the broader four-nation BCIM-EC framework to dissolve. Subsequently, India did not join the China-initiated Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), though China is currently India’s largest trading partner. In the last week of June this year, China and India resumed cross-border trade through the Lipulekh Pass after a gap of six years, which analysts consider the latest sign of a cautious rapprochement between the two countries, reports South China Morning Post. In 2025, bilateral trade between China and India reached a record high of USD 155.6 billion, registering year-on-year growth of over 12 per cent, compared to USD 71.64 billion in 2015.

China-Myanmar-Bangladesh Economic Corridor (CMBEC)

During Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman’s recent visit to Beijing (June 22–26), China proposed the transnational China-Myanmar-Bangladesh Economic Corridor (CMBEC), which promises greater connectivity, trade, and multimodal transport for the stakeholder nations. Bangladesh officials said it could boost commerce, modernise their ports, and improve access to Chinese markets. It is reported that talks between Tarique Rahman and Xi Jinping in Beijing also covered the modernisation of Chattogram Port and Mongla Port. Bangladesh agreed to develop an economic zone near Mongla Port with a Chinese state-owned company. The land for an economic zone adjoining Mongla Port was originally earmarked for an India-backed project under a 2015 bilateral initiative. However, Bangladesh’s interim administration, led by Muhammad Yunus, delisted the project in 2025.

Reacting to the proposed

CMBEC and Beijing’s involvement in the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project, India’s External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on July 3 that India was closely monitoring developments in its neighbourhood and would take “appropriate measures as required.” A day earlier, Chinese Ambassador to Bangladesh Yao Wen said Beijing had first proposed the corridor more than a decade ago under the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar (BCIM) framework, when India was also envisaged as a participant. India had not responded at the time, he said, adding that the initiative remained open to other countries, including India.

The proposed route of the transnational economic corridor, CMBEC, would begin in Kunming in China’s Yunnan Province; pass through Mandalay in Myanmar before splitting towards Yangon and Kyaukphyu; and eventually link with Bangladesh’s Chattogram and Cox’s Bazar through road and railway routes.

The Muse-Mandalay Railway Project (MMRP), unveiled in 2011, is a major part of the China-Myanmar Economic Corridor (CMEC) and the broader Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), which includes the construction of a Pan-Asian Railway Network running through Myanmar, Vietnam, Thailand, and Cambodia. Proposed to be built by Myanmar’s state-run Myanma Railways and the China Railway Eryuan Engineering Group

(CREEG), the MMRP would link Kunming, the capital of China’s southern Yunnan Province, and Mandalay in central Myanmar through the Muse border in Shan State. Under the CMEC framework, the proposal is also to extend the line from Mandalay to the Kyaukphyu Special Economic Zone (KP SEZ) and New Yangon City, the two other key sites of China-Myanmar infrastructure projects. China is developing a deep-sea port at Kyaukphyu, a city on the Bay of Bengal in Rakhine State. An 800-kilometre China-Myanmar Oil and Gas Pipeline, which began operations in 2009, has been running from Kyaukphyu through the Mandalay and Magway regions and northern Shan State. Once completed, the rail line will allow Chinese trade to bypass the congested Strait of Malacca.

Interestingly, the British also had an ambitious project to build a railway aimed at promoting trade between India and China and transporting labour from the subcontinent to Arakan, now Rakhine State. The proposed railway was to link Chittagong and Mandalay via Sittwe, then known as Akyab. It was to connect with a line linking Mandalay with Kunming in China’s Yunnan Province via Bhamo. In 1918, work began on a railway that the British hoped would provide a trade link between the subcontinent and China, but the project never materialised.

CMBEC is strategically very important for China for the smooth functioning of its global supply chain. After establishing

China’s access to the Arabian Sea through the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), Beijing now plans to strengthen its strategic presence in the Bay of Bengal by extending its existing China-Myanmar Economic Corridor (CMEC) to Bangladesh. New ports in the Bay of Bengal will reduce China’s dependence on the Strait of Malacca by establishing an alternative route to this strategic chokepoint. The Strait of Malacca—a narrow stretch of water, 900 kilometres long and 65 to 250 kilometres wide, between the Malay Peninsula to the northeast and the Indonesian island of Sumatra to the southwest, connecting the Andaman Sea (Indian Ocean) and the South China Sea (Pacific Ocean)—is the main shipping channel between the Indian and Pacific Oceans. It carries about 25 per cent of global seaborne trade and roughly two-thirds of China’s total maritime trade. While the cargo encompasses a wide variety of goods, roughly 80 per cent of China’s imported crude oil passes through this narrow chokepoint.

Analysts argue that Beijing intends to extend the China-Myanmar Economic Corridor to Bangladesh as part of its larger Maritime Belt and Road Initiative to strengthen its presence in the Indian Ocean.

Option before India

China has established strategic ports around India in the Bay of Bengal, the Arabian Sea, and the Indian Ocean. These include Djibouti (at the Horn of Africa),

THE
FUTURE OF ASIAN
CONNECTIVITY MAY DEPEND
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corridors
THAN ON WHETHER OLD
GEOPOLITICAL MISTRUST CAN
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PRAGMATISM

Gwadar (Pakistan), Hambantota (Sri Lanka), Kyaukphyu (Myanmar), and Mongla (Bangladesh). Through these ports, China seeks to strengthen its maritime presence along the strategic trade routes of the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean.

To counter Chinese influence, India aligned with the United States, Japan, and Australia and became an active member of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad). The rationale behind the Quad was to defend the international rules-based order, implying that China had become a threat to that order. Beijing, too, perceived it as an initiative aimed at containing its rise. It quickly sent formal notes of concern to the four foreign ministries in 2007. Beijing argued that the Quad formed part of a U.S.-led effort of “containment and suppression” and expressed concern that an “Indo-Pacific North Atlantic Treaty Organisation” might emerge. Recently, the U.S. Defense Department renamed

the Indo-Pacific Command (INDOPACOM) as Pacific Command (PACOM), restoring its original title. Combined with the November 2025 U.S. National Security Strategy’s use of “Asia” rather than “Indo-Pacific”, the move was interpreted by policy experts as a retreat from a concept that has shaped regional diplomacy for nearly a decade. For India, the implications could extend well beyond terminology, as dropping the “Indo” from Pacific Command adds pressure to India-U.S. ties, observes Nikkei Asia.

As the United States—India’s trusted strategic partner for decades—has practically abandoned the Quad, it would be prudent for India to revive the stalled BCIM-EC initiative. It may be recalled that last year, while inaugurating the Rising Northeast Summit held in New Delhi during May 23–24, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said that the Northeast would emerge as a gateway to trade with the ASEAN bloc over the coming decade. “The Northeast will be a strong bridge of trade with Southeast Asia. We are working on the necessary infrastructure to realise that goal,” he said, announcing that India is working on projects to directly connect Myanmar, Thailand, Vietnam, and Laos with India. “These projects will give the Northeast a new commercial identity among the Indo-Pacific countries,” he added. The much-hyped ‘Look East’ policy, initiated in 1991, also projected Northeast India as a gateway to East and Southeast Asia.

India and Myanmar share a 1,643-kilometre land border that runs from China in the north to Bangladesh in the south, covering the Indian states of Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, and Mizoram. Arunachal Pradesh also shares land borders with Bhutan and China. Over the years, three possible gateways from Northeast India to Southeast Asia via Myanmar have been discussed. These are: (i) the India-Myanmar-Thailand Highway through Moreh (Manipur) and Tamu (Myanmar); (ii) the Kaladan Multimodal Project (KMP) through Sittwe seaport and the Kaladan River in Myanmar; and (iii) the Ledo Road/Stilwell Road, the earliest modern link road connecting China’s Kunming Province with Assam. The first two projects have failed due to prolonged political disturbances in Manipur, Mizoram, and their adjoining border areas in Myanmar.

The recent announcement to resume border trade between India and Myanmar at Pangsau Pass has reinvigorated the possibility of the third gateway—the Stilwell Road. The Pangsau-Nampong border trade gate is a vital economic artery connecting India’s northeastern state of Arunachal Pradesh with Myanmar’s Sagaing Region. The decision to resume trade was finalised during a July 9 meeting between the Pangsau Market Committee and India’s Nampong Border Trade and Business Association (NBTBA). The gate was originally closed on February 3, 2020, at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. The Pangsau gate serves as a lifeline for the people of the Naga Self-Administered Zone and the upper Sagaing Region.

The Ledo Road/Stilwell Road—the earliest modern link road connecting China’s Yunnan Province with Assam—was built between 1942 and 1944 during the Second World War. The Stilwell Road was constructed to connect Ledo (Assam) to the Burmese towns of Myitkyina and Bhamo on the Burma Road, which ran from Rangoon to Kunming in China. It was built by the Allied forces to maintain supplies to China after Japan blocked China’s coastline from 1937 to 1945, making an overland route necessary. The Chinese Army had earlier built the Burma Road connecting Kunming to Rangoon. However, when Rangoon was captured by the Japanese in March 1942, the U.S. Army began constructing the Ledo Road as an alternative route linking Ledo to the Burma Road. The Ledo Road opened in early 1945. The 1,726-kilometre road traverses 61 kilometres in India, 1,033 kilometres in Myanmar, and 632 kilometres in China.

The all-weather Stilwell Road from Ledo to Kunming could become the major gateway for India to East Asia via Myanmar and China. The BCIM-EC—the sub-regional economic bloc that proposes to connect Southwest China with Eastern India through Myanmar and Bangladesh—should be made operational for the sustainable and peaceful development of the region. There is no alternative to peaceful co-existence with neighbouring countries.

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Not long ago, Rs 10 lakh could buy a premium car. Today, it only buys you a base compact SUV. India's market has quietly rewritten your definition of affordability

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

There was a time when walking into a car showroom with a budget of Rs 10 lakh carried a certain swagger. Sales executives smiled warmly, the coffee was stronger, the brochures glossier and the conversation suave on features you wanted, rather than compromises you grudgingly accepted. Now, the same budget earns you an apologetic smile, a base variant and a gentle suggestion: "Sir, for just another Rs 2 lakh..."

The numbers explain the story. India's passenger vehicle sales have scaled record highs, crossing 4.6 million units in FY 2025-26, while exports touched 9 lakh-plus units, underlining how dramatically the industry has evolved and grown. A dissection of these very numbers reveals something starker – over the last few years, Rs 10 lakh quietly became the new Rs 5 lakh.

Nobody announced it. There was no government notification, no industry declaration and no consumer referendum. Yet, the transformation has been remarkable. A figure that once represented the upper end of the mass-market automobile segment has quietly drifted towards the middle, leaving buyers stretching budgets in ways they scarcely imagined a decade ago.

Inflation, of course, deserves part of the blame. But it is not the whole story. Not at all.

COSTLY PROGRESS

Cars today are undeniably better. Safer, cleaner, more refined and sophisticated than the machines that rolled out of factories 10 or 15 years ago. Multiple airbags, ABS, electronic

stability control, stronger crash structures, rear parking cameras, tyre pressure monitoring systems and ever-tightening emission norms have transformed the modern automobile. These improvements save lives. They are not luxuries. But every regulatory upgrade, however desirable, inevitably nudges the sticker price upwards. For they cost money.

Every additional safety regulation, emissions upgrade and layer of mandatory technology adds to the final invoice. Add the Goods and Services Tax, compensation cess applicable to larger vehicles, registration charges, insurance, road tax and extended warranties, and the final number at the bottom of the invoice resembles a lusty figure that you thought only your rich, corrupt uncle's charsi son could afford.

Ironically, most consumers welcome many of these changes. And few would willingly return to the era of flimsy body shells and minimal occupant protection. Yet, the combined effect has been unmistakable on your pocket, with affordability has retreating into a far, dark corner.

ASPIRATION ENGINE

The more fascinating change, however, has occurred inside the buyer's mind. Manufacturers no longer sell cars. They sell lifestyles and aspirations. The humble hatchback, once the default choice of the middle class, has quietly surrendered the spotlight to the SUV. The country's bestselling models today sit higher, look tougher and promise adventure, even if their daily expedition means driving to the nearby supermarket or the office parking lot.

Marketing has played its role. Brilliantly. Ground clearance has become confidence. Large alloy wheels have become a status symbol. Panoramic sunroofs – perhaps the least-used feature in India's tropical climate – have become indispensable dinner-table conversation. Touchscreens have expanded faster than our roads.

Somewhere, 'Top-End Variant' has acquired an almost mythical status. Buyers finance features they never expected to own because monthly EMIs

make larger numbers appear deceptively manageable. The psychology is simple. Few ask if they can afford the car; most only ask if they can manage the monthly instalment. This subtle shift has changed the economics of the automobile market.

PREMIUM TRAP

Manufacturers understand this better than anyone. Across the industry, auto firms are realizing that selling fewer, better-equipped vehicles often makes better business sense than chasing sheer volumes with bare-bones entry-level models. 'Premiumisation' has become the industry's new favourite word. And it is not difficult to understand why.

Adding connected technology, larger wheels, cosmetic enhancements or

from it. Indian consumers deserve safer vehicles. Cleaner engines. Better quality. Smarter technology. Global standards should never become optional merely because affordability remains a concern.

Yet, there is another conversation worth having. If first-time ownership steadily moves out of reach for young families, professionals and small entrepreneurs, the industry risks narrowing its own customer base. That matters because every thriving automobile market ultimately depends on a healthy pipeline of first-time buyers. If entry-level ownership steadily slips beyond reach, today's used-car customer may become tomorrow's lost new-car customer.

Mobility has long been one of India's most powerful instruments of economic empowerment. Pricing millions of aspiring buyers towards the used-car market – or out of ownership altogether – would be an unintended consequence that deserves attention.

Perhaps the answer lies not in building cheaper cars, but in creating a policy environment that makes safe cars more affordable. Rationalising taxes on smaller, cleaner vehicles, encouraging localisation of advanced technologies and reducing compliance costs could help preserve accessibility without compromising safety.

DREAM OR DESTINATION

After all, the dream should not become more expensive than the destination. The automobile industry has every reason to celebrate its remarkable transformation. It manufactures world-class products, exports to dozens of countries and serves as a global engineering and innovation hub. Indian buyers today enjoy more choice than at any point in history.

Yet, somewhere between airbags and algorithms, emissions and electronics, aspiration and affordability, Rs 10 lakh has quietly lost its purchasing power. And the truly remarkable part? Most of us barely noticed. Perhaps the greatest triumph of India's auto market is not that it persuaded millions to buy more expensive cars. It persuaded them to believe that they always wanted to.

REALITY CHECK

None of this suggests that India is moving in the wrong direction. Far



WELLNESS

BUILDING SAFE CONVERSATIONS



The safest children are not always those who know the right answers, but those who know home is the safest place to tell the truth

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

Every evening, millions of Indian parents ask the same three questions. Did you eat? Did you sleep? Did you finish your homework?

Important questions. But they tell us almost nothing about our child's emotional world.

This week, India was shaken by videos allegedly showing toddlers being physically abused at an on-campus daycare facility inside Capgemini's Brookfield office in Bengaluru. Five workers have been arrested. The Karnataka State Commission for Protection of Child Rights is examining the case. Parents across the country are asking one question: how will I know if something is wrong with my child?

The answer, perhaps counterintuitively, does not begin with teaching children to report abuse. It begins much earlier, by building a home where a child feels safe enough to talk about anything at all.

As a psychiatrist, the biggest misconception I encounter is that children disclose difficult experiences because an adult asked exactly the right question. They do not. Children disclose because they feel safe enough to answer. Psychologists call this psychological safety, which is the felt sense that I can tell my parent anything and I will not be ignored, dismissed or blamed. That safety is not built during a crisis but instead is built in ordinary conversations, repeated every single day.

AGES 2 TO 5: HELP THEM NAME FEELINGS

Young children think in pictures, play and emotion. Skip "How was school?" It produces nothing. Make it concrete instead.

What made you smile today? Did anyone help you? Was there anything that made your tummy feel funny? If today had a colour, what colour would it be?

At this age, do not rush to solve. Children communicate through stories, pretend play and drawings long before they find words. Your job is to be curious, not corrective.

AGES 5 TO 8: BUILD CURIOSITY, NOT INTERROGATION

Children now have better language but worry about getting into trouble. Rapid-fire questioning shuts them down. Weave conversation into existing routines

like dinner, the drive home, bedtime.

What was the best part of today? Was anyone feeling left out? Who made you feel happy, safe or uncomfortable today?

These questions teach children that every emotion is welcome in this house, not just the easy ones.

AGES 8 TO 12: BECOME A LISTENER, NOT AN INVESTIGATOR

Older children are better at hiding what is actually happening. Resist the urge to interrogate and instead create space.

What was the hardest part of your day? Was there a moment you wished an adult had stepped in? What is something you have been thinking about but have not told anyone yet?

Notice that none of these questions asks "Did someone hurt you?" That is intentional. Children are far more likely to share important information when a conversation feels natural rather than like a formal inquiry.

Emotional safety is built through everyday conversations, not crisis interventions

THE HABITS THAT HOLD IT ALL TOGETHER

Listen without immediately judging or interrupting. Avoid dismissing feelings with phrases like "don't be silly" or "it is not a big deal." When your child tells you something difficult, even something that seems minor, thank them for it. That response tells them the channel is open.

Most importantly, make this a daily ritual rather than something that happens only when you are already worried. By the time you are worried, the window may already be narrower than you think.

The goal is not to raise children who never encounter difficulty. It is to raise children who know exactly where to take difficulty when it arrives.

Because when something serious happens, and life guarantees that something eventually will, your child is unlikely to remember the one perfect question you asked. They will remember something far more important.

That home was always a safe place to tell the truth.



A River of Many Stories



Spanning more than 160 years, *Colour My Grave Purple* blends history, folklore and memory into a richly layered portrait of Assam, where rivers, revolts and identities flow together

AUTHOR

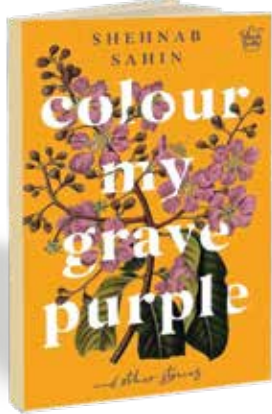


YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

“The history of Assam and its people is as meandering as the mighty Brahmaputra that flows through it,” writes Shehnab Sahin in the Author’s Note to her debut collection of short fiction. To explore this vast riverine coast without losing the rhythm of different waves is the aim of this book. An ambitious timeline, from 1958 to 2019, merges historical fiction into contemporary currents. Natural and supernatural exist in the same waters, amidst tides of ancient spiritual faiths recalibrating to new religious depths.

From 1858 is the story “Two Leaves and a Bud” about botanist Samuel Addington, a British empire-builder whose commission to study the *Camellia sinensis* funded his travels to China, Nepal, Bhutan, and finally the Chinnamara Tea Estate in Assam, where he arrived as manager along with his pregnant Cantonese wife. A year prior, a local aristocrat known as Maniram Dewan had conspired with rebels to reinstate Ahom rule. He had been publicly hanged to death for this revolt. Yet his legacy continued to haunt the estate and its new occupants — the “ojha” occult practitioner who could perhaps have helped appease his spirit, whom the Kachari tribals wanted to call, was not summoned by the rational white manager.

“Freedom in My Blood (1920)” also makes brief mention of an ojha. Ten-year-old Mamoni is experiencing menarche, and an unsettling first sight of blood followed by a strange new world of atonements reminds her of a mantra taught by her powerful grandmother to weaken enemies. Isolated in a separate room by her ritualistic mother, Mamoni begins to write a letter to the Mahatma who is scheduled to visit her state soon: “Dear Gandhiji, ... Jai Hind...” She is unsure about what else



can be written. “She wanted Gandhiji to know how very excited she was to see such a great man and how she would join him like her father and brothers and drive the British out of her country.” Warriors bleed at home and in the world; battlegrounds require distance from family; strength appears in unexpected satyagrahas.

If “Bellows of a Wilted Poppy” from 1860 highlights kancee - opium - used traditionally in medicine by “bez” healer Rebo until the British came up with an elaborate self-serving scheme to commercialise it, “Ursula (1943)” begins with soothsayer Ramgakpa leaving his study of mystical mushrooms to examine the sand-patterns created by a python as an oracle of what was to come: “queen, war, memory.” The eponymous Miss Ursula Graham Bower, or “Naga Queen”, was asked to assist refugees fleeing from Japanese attacks in Burma. Laisong locals - who had been cultivating for the British for nearly a century - began preparing for a world war in which they had no direct stakes. Their former ways of life would be memorialized

in the photographs of “Uu-su-la Memsahab.”

After the Independence of India, there are “Sunsets in the East (1962)”. The advance of Chinese troops push a far-sighted bank manager in Tezpur to burn currency notes and dump coins in a pond, whilst the inmates of a mental asylum are set free, and Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru expresses his sympathies for Assam on the radio. A decade later, in “Devotional Defiance”, cinema and theatre become avenues of escape for young men trapped in rigid village norms: “The harmony is lost, my brothers,” says an actor depicting a raiz mel discussion, “If our music has started pouring out sounds of despair, it is because we have allowed others to play us.” In “Alliances (1986)”, friendships are fractured over political revolt when young men from the village begin joining the Asom Gana Parishad to protest the illegal hordes of Bangladeshi refugees taking up slim opportunities for employment in their state.

Perhaps the most moving story in Sahin’s collection is the titular “Colour My Grave Purple (1980-2000s)”. Sara makes meaning from signs the universe offers. After the death of her father, a police officer stationed in Assam for much of her life, she searches for catharsis in the pages of his journals. She had been sheltered from the worst sorrows of his career, she realises, as she reads the chilling descriptions of the ULFA insurgency and militancy he had seen as a public servant in a troubled state. “While so much violence tainted people’s everyday lives, she only

remembered boat rides across the Baghor river, spotting a river dolphin for the first time in her life with her father beside her, his thrill more childlike than hers.” He had made sure to share his love of nature in a biodiverse state. Years later, when Sara visits his final resting place in a kabristan from which she had earlier been forbidden due to her gender, she discovers proof irrefutable of an offering by a benevolent universe.

STRETCHING FROM COLONIAL RULE TO CONTEMPORARY INDIA, THE ANTHOLOGY COMBINES *historical* FICTION, FOLKLORE AND DEEPLY PERSONAL NARRATIVES TO ILLUMINATE A REGION OFTEN OVERLOOKED IN MAINSTREAM INDIAN LITERATURE

“Animal Instinct (2004)” and “Love is a Flimsy Kite (2019)” both feature young women studying in Delhi University as protagonists. Ideals blur into self-righteousness and self-preservation differently based on whom the young women speak to — a “new driver who had been assigned to her that morning for the airport drop as her regular driver had to attend to some official duty”, versus a lover with a “broad chest and sinewy arms and the lingering smell of Axe Chocolate, sweat and cigarettes that she has grown to fawn over”. The degrees of reflection which her exchanges prompt vary as well, but something in the nature of Sahin’s reflective writing suggest that while the book ends here, the stories are likely to continue beyond its pages.

Each of the ten stories in *Colour My Grave Purple* map the shifting shores of Axomiya identity over the centuries as they have silted into the understudied paradoxes which characterise contemporary Assam. From traditional witchcraft, animist shamanism, Vaishnavite Hinduism, evangelical Christianity, Tibetan Buddhism, and Sylheti Islam to the gendered tensions and contested politics which are mired under these surfaces, this anthology builds a bridge to a fascinating land defined by the mighty, unquiet Brahmaputra.

SPENDING TOO MUCH TIME ON YOUR PHONE? HERE’S HOW TO CUT BACK

Do you find yourself checking your phone every few minutes? It’s a habit many of us have picked up without even noticing. The good news is that reducing your screen time doesn’t have to be overwhelming. If you’ve been thinking about cutting back on screen time but aren’t sure where to start, a few simple changes can make a big difference.



START BY TRACKING YOUR SCREEN TIME

The first step is knowing how much time you’re actually spending on your phone. Most smartphones have built-in screen time or digital wellbeing features that show how long you use different apps. You may be surprised to see where most of your time goes. Once you know your habits, it becomes easier to decide what needs to change.

TURN OFF UNNECESSARY NOTIFICATIONS

Every buzz, ping or pop-up pulls your attention away from whatever you’re doing. Unless it’s something important like calls or work-related messages, consider switching off notifications for social media, shopping or gaming apps. Fewer interruptions often mean fewer reasons to unlock your phone.



CREATE PHONE-FREE ZONES AND HOURS

Keeping your phone away during meals, while spending time with family or before going to bed can make a noticeable difference. You can also decide on specific hours during the day when you won’t use your phone unless absolutely necessary. These small boundaries help build healthier habits over time.

REPLACE SCROLLING WITH ANOTHER ACTIVITY

Many people reach for their phones simply because they’re bored. Instead, try replacing that habit with something else. Reading a few pages of a book, taking a short walk, listening to music, cooking, journaling or even watering your plants can help shift your focus away from the screen while giving your mind a break.



REMOVE THE BIGGEST DISTRACTIONS

If certain apps constantly tempt you to keep scrolling, make them a little harder to access. You can log out after each use, move them off your home screen or set daily app limits. Some people even take short breaks from social media by deleting apps for a few days. A little distance can make it easier to regain control.

COMFORT FOOD RECIPES PERFECTLY REIMAGINED FOR RAINY DAYS

Rainy days have a way of changing what we crave. A warm bowl of soup, a freshly baked treat, or a hearty one-pot meal can turn a gloomy afternoon into something comforting. The best comfort foods don’t just warm you up, they also bring familiar flavours with a fresh twist. Here are classic comfort food recipes that have been perfectly reimagined for rainy days.



CREAMY TOMATO SOUP WITH ROASTED RED PEPPERS

Traditional tomato soup gets an upgrade with smoky roasted red peppers blended into the mix. Pair it with grilled cheese made using sourdough and sharp cheddar for an elevated take on a timeless favourite.



ONE-POT MUSHROOM AND HERB RISOTTO

Instead of standing over the stove stirring endlessly, this simplified one-pot risotto captures all the creamy richness of the Italian classic while earthy mushrooms and fragrant herbs make it ideal for chilly weather.



MASALA MAC AND CHEESE

Classic mac and cheese meets bold spices like cumin, turmeric, and garam masala. Finished with crispy breadcrumbs and fresh cilantro, this fusion dish delivers creamy comfort with an exciting kick.



SWEET POTATO SHEPHERD’S PIE

Swap traditional mashed potatoes for creamy sweet potatoes to create a lighter yet satisfying shepherd’s pie. A filling of lentils or seasoned minced meat makes this meal both wholesome and comforting.

CHAI-SPICED RICE PUDDING

Classic rice pudding gets a fragrant makeover with cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, and a touch of ginger. Served warm with chopped pistachios or almonds, it’s the perfect rainy-day dessert.



One Last Dance For Greatness

AUTHOR



S KANNAN



As Lionel Messi prepares for another World Cup final, football celebrates a timeless genius while Spain's youthful brilliance promises a defining clash for the sport's future

It has been a whirlwind tour of sorts in the FIFA World Cup, with teams flying across cities and time zones this time. Now comes the final showdown, with Superman Lionel Messi leading Argentina against an inspired Spain in Sunday's blockbuster to be held in New Jersey.

Just to put in perspective what transpired in the last two matches, Spain produced a classic against France, with 19-year-old Lamine Yamal now becoming a household name. Images of Yamal being gently patted by Messi when he was a youngster have stormed the internet. So, when Messi faces Yamal and Spain, it will be an interesting contest — a 39-year-old versus the teen star. What Argentina did in the semi-final, producing magic in a crucial 7-0 win against England, left the Three Lions broken, hearts included.

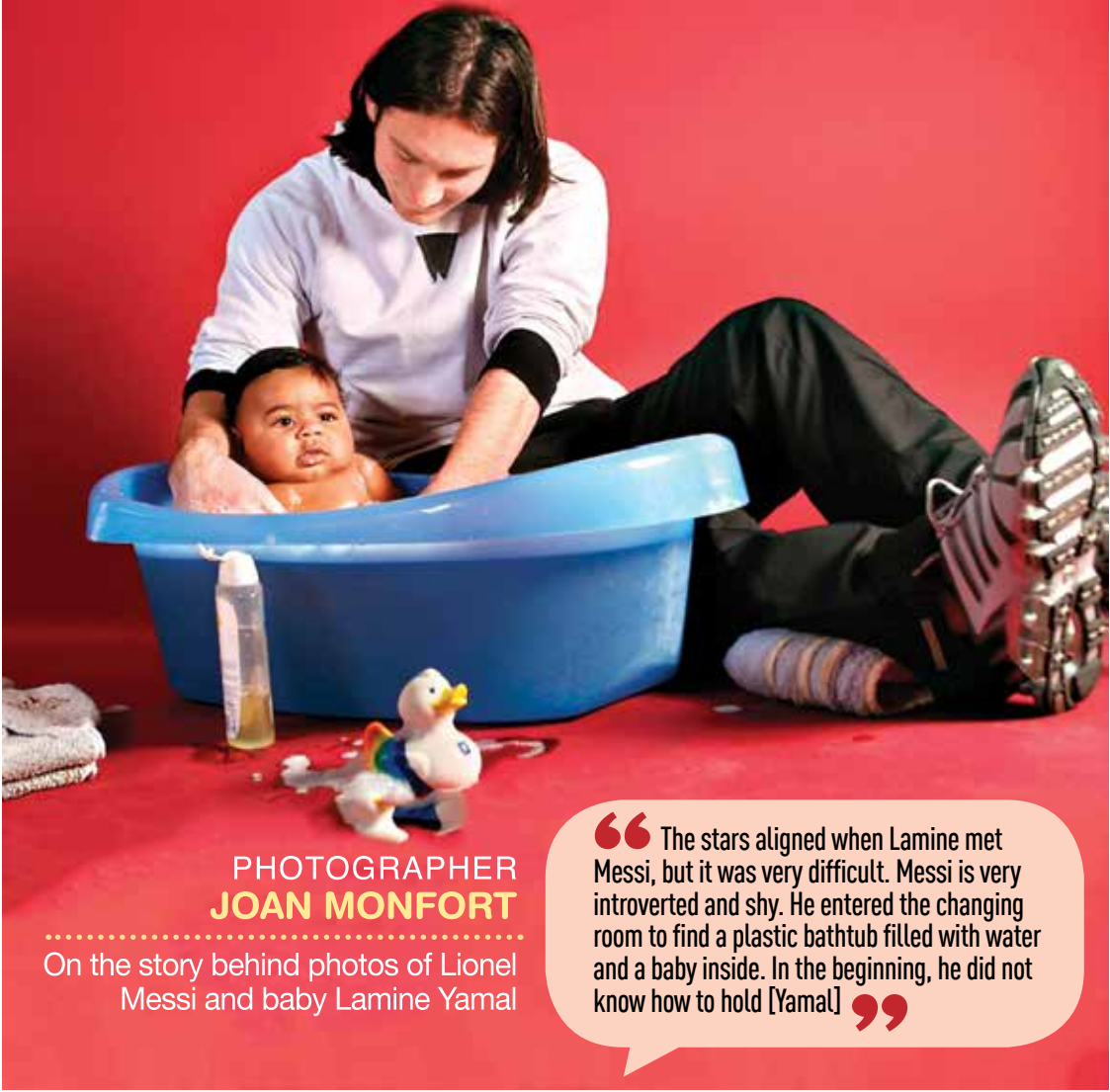
What a journey this has been in the World Cup, where fans saw brilliant bursts even from teams that did not make it to the last 16 stage. The football on view, in terms of quality, offered from across several continents was outstanding. If Argentina and Spain stand at the Final Frontier, they have prepared hard and delivered.

Just rewind to the predictions before the World Cup began. Fans and bookmakers were dead sure France, where the imposing presence of Kylian Mbappe made a strong impact, would win the World Cup. On a Richter scale of 1 to 10, France losing to Spain would measure at 9. Not because predictions went wrong, but because France looked too good, with Mbappe and his teammates in command. But then Spain came up with a display that was so different. Cutting off the midfield supply, Spain had planned well against France. The difference was who played better on that day — Spain, not France. To say the performance was flawless from Spain, the champions of Europe and the 2010 World Cup winners, would be stating the obvious.

Now comes Lamine Yamal, the wunderkind. The boy who was being petted by Messi 19 years ago, innocently, when he was two years old, has grown up to become a major football force. As a right winger, Yamal has done brilliant work for his clubs as well as for the Spain national team. Being young and energetic, with an infectious level of enthusiasm, Yamal has been portrayed as a darling. There is nothing wrong with that, since sport keeps searching for new stars. Perhaps, this World Cup is the real birth of Yamal as a hero, a young football champion in the making.

He has all the ingredients to be a celebrity so early in life. Yamal has handled it all well till now. After all, the average age of players in La Roja is 26.1, compared to Argentina's 28.5. That is largely because Messi is 39. For Spain, the fresher and younger legs will surely be of help in the final. However, as things

IN 2007, LIONEL MESSI GENTLY BATHED A BABY DURING A CHARITY PHOTO SHOOT. 19 YEARS LATER, THAT SAME BABY, LAMINE YAMAL, STANDS IN HIS WAY IN A FIFA WORLD CUP FINAL



PHOTOGRAPHER
JOAN MONFORT

On the story behind photos of Lionel Messi and baby Lamine Yamal

“The stars aligned when Lamine met Messi, but it was very difficult. Messi is very introverted and shy. He entered the changing room to find a plastic bathtub filled with water and a baby inside. In the beginning, he did not know how to hold [Yamal]”

fantasised about Pele and Diego Maradona being the greatest, the time has come to change the title.

To be sure, Messi has nothing more to prove. He has achieved awards and rewards, and he lifted the World Cup in 2022. The presence of Messi in 2026 is a bonus for all football fans. Thank him for it, since he is a once-in-a-lifetime generational rock star. A Lionel Messi is not born every day. A Lionel Messi cannot be created in a human laboratory, even with the most modern advancements in genetic engineering. The real impact of Messi will be felt when he walks into the sunset. That day will be a sad one, for he has provided magical moments for decades in football, delivering a masterclass every time.

As the World Cup comes to a close, one can praise the three nations that hosted it — Canada, Mexico and the USA. New Jersey will host the final on a packed Sunday night, where only the privileged can enter the arena. For the USA, which won the right to host the World Cup, this has been a great learning experience. Yes, there were problems faced by teams such as Iran early on.

Today, the world is far from peaceful. The Russia-Ukraine war has raged for over four years. Iran continues to burn, and finding reasons for it is next to impossible. At a time when there is so much turmoil, football has acted like a balm for all of us. As for those who have slammed FIFA and its president, Gianni Infantino, who has been in charge since 2016, he continues to be a strong sports administrator. His proposal to increase the size of the World Cup to 48 teams in four years has faced criticism. There is a market for a bigger World Cup and, if more teams can come in, why not?

Did we not cheer for the minnows this time, Cape Verde and Curacao? Even with Google Maps, finding these small nations can be a task. They provided football fans with magical moments. I am all for enlarging the size of the World Cup. Indeed, there is a need for greater representation from more continents. Football is truly a unifying sport that cuts across everything else. Let it boom. For those of us who slept less and are left blurry-eyed, we will wait for the New Jersey finale.

Argentina once more, or Spain as champions again? Wait. The final few hours are filled with great expectations.

Away from football, there is massive speculation that Sunday will also be Rohit Sharma's last match against England at Lord's. The Hitman is being forced out of the squad, which is saddening. He has not become a liability; it is just that coach Gautam Gambhir and chairman of the selection committee Ajit Agarkar have their own agendas. Hopefully, the BCCI will not remain a mute spectator. Don't treat Rohit Sharma like a wastrel. Please.

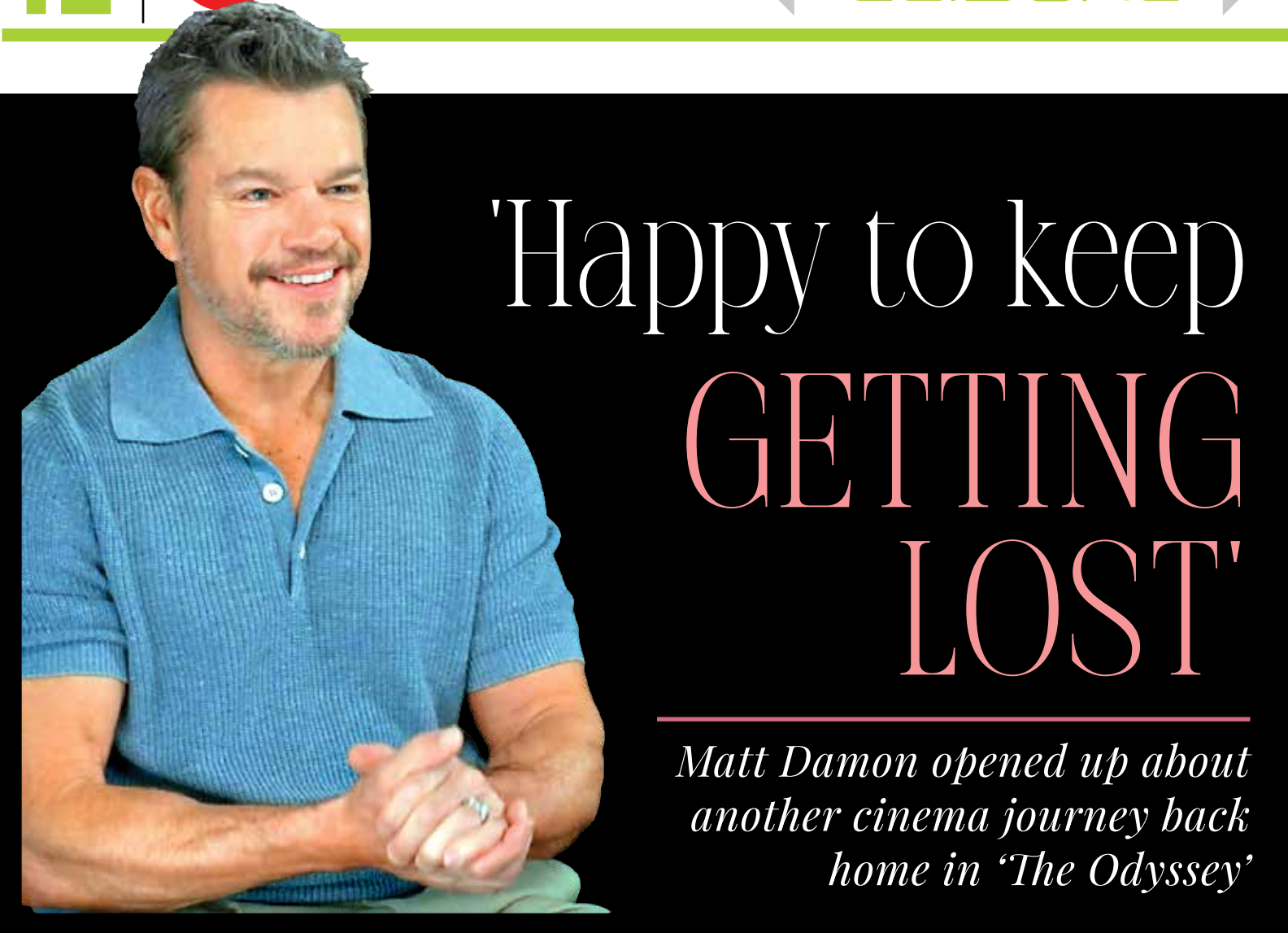
stand, none can predict the outcome of this final contest.

Take the case of Messi, the master. He was not supposed to have been around for so long, featuring in a sixth FIFA World Cup. As the defending champions, for Argentina to keep going has been remarkable. And the best part is that the side does not rely only on Messi to score or create moves up front. What one witnessed in a revisit of the 'Falklands War' was Argentina exploding in the final minutes of extra time to flatten England. It left the perennial contenders in tears on the turf. For those who marvel at Messi, the God of football, the kind of presence he showed in the crucial semi-final, creating movement, orchestrating attacks and delivering crosses, will go down as mind-blowing.

A deep dive into Messi shows he is indeed 'The Greatest'. He has handled age so well that it is a lesson for everyone who thinks adding years is a limiting factor. "Messi has matured" is easy to say from the comfort of a couch at home. To be on the turf for such long durations, remain fit, keep moving his legs and continue producing magic, Messi has transformed himself. He has used science, fitness, nutrition and workouts to his advantage. And this, for someone who early in life battled a growth hormone deficiency (GH). Messi had to be cared for in this regard in Spain when he was around 11 years old. There is a lot

of Spain in Messi, as it is this country that witnessed his growth. He also underwent hormone injections there more than 27 years ago.

Over the years, the way Messi has preserved himself is a wonderful story. He has taken care of his workouts, including modifying his diet. If he is still so energetic and continues to produce a potent brand of football, Messi has shown that age is not a deterrent. In this sport, where he literally runs miles, doing all this is no fluke. Official statistics say that against England, he ran almost 8 km on the field. The way he recovers and prepares for the next match offers so much to learn from the Argentine legend. Certainly, for generations that



Matt Damon opened up about another cinema journey back home in 'The Odyssey'

BEDIKA

He is quite happy to keep getting lost, said Matt Damon, who has done so in several earlier films and now again in a cinematic and personal journey that has been epic in every which way - playing Odysseus in Christopher Nolan's ambitious retelling of Homer's 'The Odyssey'.

"It was fantastic. It was the experience of a lifetime," the Hollywood superstar told PTI in an interview.

Getting lost has been quite the running theme in his films. And now comes 'The Odyssey' about the Greek mythological hero on a journey back to Ithaca. "The movies where I get to come home so far are 'Saving Private Ryan', 'Interstellar', 'The Martian' and this one. So, I'm happy to keep getting lost," Damon said.

"The Odyssey", Nolan's first film that had a gala premiere in India, somehow tops all his earlier experiences.

Damon said he is just happy he got to embody the character of Odysseus. This story is almost 3,000 years old and has inspired countless poems, stories, paintings, movies and other art for centuries now, in Nolan's big-screen adaptation. He gets to distil his experience of almost four decades in cinema and many blockbusters in playing the battle-weary hero haunted by his choices and desperate to go home to his wife and son in Ithaca. During the decade-long journey after the Trojan War, he confronts vengeful gods, mythical creatures and much more.

The actor, who won the Academy Award with friend Ben Affleck for writing 'Good Will Hunting', went on to build an enviable body of work in the 'Bourne' and 'Ocean's' franchise as well as movies such as 'The Talented Mr Ripley', 'The Rainmaker' and 'The Departed'. The filmography also includes Nolan's 'Interstellar' and 'Oppenheimer'.

Graduating to Nolan's leading man has been great. "I love working with Chris. I love his approach. I love his crew. And it's always such a pure work experience. I mean, he



just elevates the project and puts it in the centre and everybody just checks their ego and focuses on this project. And so, to finally, you know, get this huge role in what is as ambitious a movie as I'd ever seen. It was really the thrill of a lifetime."

"The Odyssey" is the most challenging film of his career, the 55-year-old said. "Some days started with a hike up a mountain and then a hike down altogether at the end of the day. And the beauty of it was that every single person was in it. There was no special treatment. And everyone was there for the love of cinema. And we knew what we were doing was really challenging. And that was the joy," he said.

Asked whether he could recall the toughest moment from the movie, Damon shook his head. "Impossible to say. I mean, we were on a boat. The number one rule in Hollywood is never to go on a boat. We were on a boat for months," he said, referencing the popular

'THE ODYSSEY' SOMEHOW TOPS ALL HIS EARLIER EXPERIENCES

Hollywood sentiment that films set in water pose a huge logistical challenge.

He added, "We were at the top of the mountains. We were in a cave that you had to hike up to get to and then we shot inside a cave for two weeks. It's just that every location presented a different challenge. And they were equally difficult, but in completely different ways."

Damon can almost be ranked an India regular. The star, who has been to India to shoot for 'The Bourne Supremacy' and for a charity project once, said he just loved

the reaction of fans to 'The Odyssey'. He got to witness it firsthand during one of the two screenings of the movie ahead of its release this weekend.

"It was very emotional because it was the first real audience. We'd seen it at premieres, but that's your family and friends, which is wonderful. But to see a pure audience, it was the first time we got the chance to engage with them right after they'd seen it. And it was really exciting," he said.

He stayed in Goa for more than a month in 2003 for 'The Bourne Supremacy'. "I have wonderful memories about being here and interacting with Indian cinema culture from the other side, from the crew side. We had a local crew. They were awesome. And that sequence in that movie really set up the rest of that franchise. It's the first act of the second film. And it was a critical act to get right."

In 'The Odyssey', Damon leads an ensemble cast that also includes Holland, Anne Hathaway, Zendaya, Lupita Nyong'o, Robert Pattinson, Charlize Theron, Samantha Morton, Jon Bernthal, Benny Safdie and John Leguizamo. The movie, the first to be shot fully on IMAX cameras, has a dazzling scale that rivals Nolan's past works. According to Damon, 'The Odyssey' is a film to be experienced on the big screen. "I think Nolan has put all of the skill that he's built over his incredible career and he brought it all on this project because this project is like six movies in one. And you see everything he has in his toolkit in this movie. And it's all been captured on the largest format that's ever been done. So, it's definitely one to see at the cinema," the actor said.

'The Odyssey' is the first film to be shot entirely on an IMAX film camera. "They invented a system that could quiet the camera, which, when it was on the camera, weighed over 300 pounds. So, imagine these grips (camera technicians) carrying this stuff around up mountains. I mean, I would get to locations and just shake my head and go, who thought we should shoot a movie here? This is crazy," he said. AGENCIES

'NEVER BEEN ANYWHERE WITH SUCH APPRECIATION FOR MOVIES'



Filmmaker Christopher Nolan talked about bringing 'The Odyssey' to India

Filmmaker Christopher Nolan said he wanted to bring one of his films to India for a premiere, especially 'Tenet', which was partly shot in Mumbai, but the COVID-19 pandemic derailed those plans.

The filmmaker has finally realised that dream with the Indian premiere of his latest directorial, 'The Odyssey', adapted from Homer's epic poem.

Nolan, known for movies such as 'The Dark Knight' trilogy, 'Inception', 'Interstellar', 'Dunkirk' and 'Oppenheimer', was in Mumbai along with the film's two lead stars, Matt Damon and Tom Holland.

The Oscar winner said Indian audiences have always shared a special connection with cinema, making the country an obvious choice for the event.

"We actually intended to come with 'Tenet' originally, because we filmed here in Mumbai and then because of the pandemic, we weren't able to. And so finally, we're actually able to. It's a thrill. We wanted to do this for a year," the director said at a press conference in Mumbai.

Nolan has visited India several times, shooting portions of 'The Dark Knight Rises' (2012) in Jodhpur and 'Tenet' (2020) in Mumbai. He also recalled an earlier visit when filmmaker and film archivist Shivendra Singh Dungarpur invited him to attend a conference on the future of film.

"I met a lot of filmmakers and really got to know a little bit about the film culture here. I've never been anywhere in the world with an appreciation for what movies can be and should be for audiences. To me, it seemed crazy that we wouldn't be bringing our films here to premiere for one of my audiences. I'm absolutely thrilled to be able to do this. Mumbai feels special," he added.

The 55-year-old filmmaker said cinema remains a universal language that transcends borders and cultures. "I just like to think that films are a universal language. One of the things I most enjoy about working on large-scale films is that you get to take them around the world and you get to connect with different cultures all across the world. When films really connect, when they have universal themes and timeless themes, as I hope 'The Odyssey' does, it's wonderful how it kind of brings us together," he said.

Calling the India visit 'the ultimate expression' of cinema's power to unite people, Nolan said travelling across the world to watch audiences laugh and cry together is among the most rewarding aspects of filmmaking.

Nolan was in Mumbai along with the film's two lead stars, Matt Damon and Tom Holland

"It's pretty thrilling to come to a completely different place and find commonality, find entertainment together, find laughter and tears together in a movie. It's what the movie is all about, so this is the ultimate kind of expression for us. It's been really thrilling to see our films in the past connect with Indian audiences," he added.

Nolan also drew laughter with a playful reference to Holland, who stars in both 'The Odyssey' and 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day', which also comes out in theatres later this month. PTI

RACHEL MORRISON'S 'LOVE OF YOUR LIFE' TO WORLD PREMIERE AT TIFF

Starring Margaret Qualley, it will stream globally on 'Prime Video' on October 14



Directed by Rachel Morrison ('The Fire Inside'), 'Love of Your Life', starring Margaret Qualley, will have its world premiere at the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) and stream on 'Prime Video' on October 14.

It follows Maya (Qualley), whose chance encounter with Charlie (Gabriel Basso) sets in motion a sweeping romance and a future beyond anything she had imagined. When that future is suddenly upended, Maya is sent hurtling toward an unexpected new life - one that will force her to reckon with who she is, what she wants and how to love again.

With direction by Rachel Morrison and produced by Ryan Gosling and Jessie Henderson, 'Love of Your Life' also stars Aaron Pierre, Patrick Schwarzenegger, Catherine Keener, Tamara Lawrence and Corey Johnson. MPOST

